MALMÖ UNIVERSITY

AI Governance and Workforce Displacement:
Who Bears the Cost?

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Leadership and Organisation
Degree of Master of Arts (60 credits) with a Major in Leadership and Organisation
Master Thesis with a focus on Leadership and Organisation for Sustainability (OL646E), 15 credits
Spring 2026
Supervisor: Gustav Hägg

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Abstract

AI adoption is spreading rapidly, and firms respond with voluntary governance frameworks pledging responsible use. Yet companies publishing these commitments simultaneously execute workforce reductions attributed to AI. Whether such governance produces genuine accountability, or primarily legitimises the firms that publish it, is the question this inquiry addresses. Sweden provides the empirical setting, a most-likely case for substantive governance given strong institutional commitments to social sustainability and worker protection.

This inquiry takes a pragmatist position, choosing methods for the analytical work they do rather than for fit with a prior doctrine. The study employs a two-phase qualitative design. Phase 1 applies Critical Discourse Analysis to 76 governance documents across twelve AI-adopting firms operating in Sweden. Phase 2 applies Reflexive Thematic Analysis to six practitioner interviews (four HR, two Union). Three pillars structure the analytical framework (institutional isomorphism, legitimacy theory, and externality theory), with Integrative Social Contracts Theory providing the normative anchor.

The two phases converge strongly. Corporate AI governance frameworks in Sweden function primarily as legitimacy mechanisms, not as accountability mechanisms for workforce displacement. The gap is reproduced across both documents and practitioner accounts, and across convergent and divergent firm cases. Documents omit labour from governance scope and place AI-investment alongside workforce-reduction language without connecting the two. Firm-captured benefits are named while worker- and public-borne costs are silenced. Practitioners experience governance as a practical instrument for the firm, and inhabit decoupling in their own work. The pattern is structurally produced: competitive markets reward symbolic compliance over the unilateral internalisation of displacement costs. Where institutional conditions most favour substantive governance, the gap still holds. The findings imply that closing the gap is a collective-institutional problem rather than a corporate-virtue problem.

Keywords: AI governance; workforce displacement; organisational responsibility; externalities

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1. Introduction

The most important question concerning the social impact of new technology is not what it will do, but what it will undo.
Neil Postman[1]

This chapter positions the research problem within the fields of organisational leadership and sustainability, presents the aim and research questions guiding the study, and outlines the structure of the thesis.

1.1. Background

Artificial intelligence is reshaping how organizations operate, make decisions, and allocate resources. Across industries, firms are deploying AI systems to automate processes that were previously carried out by human workers, from customer service and logistics to recruitment and financial analysis (Frey & Osborne, 2017). The pace of this transformation has accelerated in recent years, with large language models expanding the range of tasks susceptible to automation well beyond routine manual work and into knowledge-intensive domains. Large-scale payroll data confirm that these effects are materializing in the labor market: Brynjolfsson, Chandar, and Chen (2025) document a 16% relative employment decline for early-career workers in AI-exposed occupations since late 2022, with effects concentrated in roles where AI automates rather than augments human labor. For organizations, the promise is efficiency and competitive advantage. For workers, the implications are less certain. The pace of this shift is empirically visible: by mid-2025, large language model adoption among US workers had reached an estimated 46 percent, and analysis of enterprise usage patterns indicates that deployments are predominantly oriented toward task automation rather than human augmentation (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025; Anthropic, 2026). The question of how organizations manage the social consequences of these transitions is fundamentally a question of leadership for sustainability. In practical terms, this is a question of what organizations actually do for affected workers: whether they provide meaningful transition support, employment stability, and protection from displacement costs. It is also a question of whether their responses to these changes function as genuine accountability or operate primarily as legitimacy instruments.

In response to the ethical and social challenges posed by AI, a growing number of organizations have adopted governance frameworks intended to guide responsible deployment. By 2019, over eighty published AI ethics guidelines had been identified across corporations, industry consortia, and public bodies (Jobin et al., 2019) and the number has continued to grow. The European Union's AI Act (Regulation 2024/1689) has added regulatory pressure for firms to demonstrate responsible AI practice. The Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive (CSRD, Directive 2022/2464), though not addressing AI explicitly, adds parallel pressure to disclose material sustainability impacts, although neither instrument grants workers specific rights with respect to AI-driven displacement (Ponce Del Castillo & Taes, 2025). In Sweden, a strong institutional context characterized by high unionization rates, comprehensive collective bargaining, and an established tradition of social partnership (Kjellberg & Nergaard, 2022) creates particularly favorable conditions for governance to be substantive rather than symbolic. Swedish firms, from established multinationals to fast-growing technology companies, have been prominent both in AI adoption and in publishing governance commitments. The governance discourse, in other words, exists and is proliferating.

Yet a paradox is visible in the empirical record. Companies that publish responsible AI commitments simultaneously execute large-scale workforce reductions attributed to AI-driven automation. Klarna, the Swedish fintech firm, deployed an OpenAI-powered chatbot in early 2024 that it claimed replaced 700 full-time customer service agents, cut headcount from 5,500 to 3,400 between 2022 and 2024, and by mid-2025 publicly reversed course (Klarna, 2024a; Siemiatkowski, 2025). IBM, despite maintaining one of the most prominent corporate responsible-AI programmes, announced in 2023 a hiring pause for

[1]Neil Postman, Technopoly: The Surrender of Culture to Technology, 1992, p. 18.

7,800 back-office positions and by mid-2025 had replaced several hundred human-resources staff with AI systems (Krishna, 2023, 2025; see §6.1.2). These cases are not isolated. They illustrate a broader pattern in which governance language and workforce outcomes operate on separate tracks, and in which the governance frameworks firms maintain rarely address the displacement consequences for affected workers (Hagendorff, 2020). The current economic turmoil, post-pandemic overhiring, tariff-driven supply-chain disruption, and softening consumer demand has supercharged the rate at which firms invoke AI as the proximate cause of workforce reductions, even where the underlying drivers are predominantly economic (CNBC, 2025; CNBC, 2026). This chapter examines why that matters.

1.2. Previous Research

The research problem sits at the intersection of three literatures. One examines the regulatory and economic conditions under which AI governance operates. A second maps the voluntary governance principles that firms adopt in response. A third documents the workforce displacement consequences of AI adoption and the attributional dynamics that surround them. Each addresses a different dimension of the same phenomenon, but they have not been brought into dialogue. This section reviews each in turn.

1.2.1 The Regulatory and Economic Context

Corporate AI governance does not emerge in an institutional vacuum. It develops within a regulatory architecture that Roberts et al. (2024) characterize as a weak regime complex: polycentric, largely siloed, and structurally constrained by interstate competition over AI as a source of economic and military advantage. The architecture is not empty. All 193 UNESCO member states adopted an AI ethics recommendation in 2021, the G7 launched the Hiroshima AI Process in 2023, and the Council of Europe has been drafting a binding convention on AI and human rights. But implementation is thin. Fewer than a quarter of UNESCO signatories have worked to implement the recommendation's policy tools, with no consequences for non-compliance (Roberts et al., 2024). Because multiple standards bodies (ISO, IEC, IEEE, ITU) hold overlapping mandates, companies can select whichever rules are most favorable, what Roberts et al. (2024) call forum shopping. The same companies that participate in developing these standards face a principal moral hazard, since they have the least to gain from making protections stringent. Industry figures have leveraged the geopolitical arms race narrative to advocate simultaneously for increased funding and reduced domestic regulation.

At the binding end, the EU AI Act (Regulation 2024/1689) introduces risk classification, obligations for general-purpose AI system providers, and fines of up to 7% of global turnover (Regulation 2024/1689, Art. 99; Ponce Del Castillo & Taes, 2025). Yet the Act is modelled on product safety regulation, not social policy, and it does not grant workers specific rights (Ponce Del Castillo & Taes, 2025). While AI systems used for recruitment, task allocation, and performance monitoring are classified as high-risk, the regulatory burden falls on AI system providers rather than on employers who deploy these systems in workplace settings. The proposed AI Liability Directive is unlikely to cover harms arising within employment relationships, given their contractual nature. The Platform Work Directive introduces protections against algorithmic management, but these apply strictly to digital labour platform workers, leaving those in traditional sectors without equivalent protection (Ponce Del Castillo & Taes, 2025). The regulatory architecture, in short, was designed to make AI products safe. It was not designed to govern what employers do with those products to their workforce.

This governance gap unfolds against economic conditions that complicate causal attribution. The post-pandemic period saw significant overhiring across technology and financial sectors, creating structural overcapacity (Stephany, as cited in CNBC, 2025). Trade policy disruption has compounded this, with tariff-driven layoffs doubling among surveyed supply chain managers between mid-2025 and January 2026 (ASCM, as cited in CNBC, 2026). Consumer demand has softened across multiple sectors. Research from the Yale Budget Lab finds that the US occupational mix has shifted little since the release of ChatGPT in 2022 (as cited in CNBC, 2025). As one management scholar observed, attributing layoffs to AI carries less political risk than citing tariffs, overhiring, or demand decline (Seamans, as cited in Fortune, 2025). A further mismatch is empirically visible at the level of deployment itself: enterprise usage data indicate that actual AI task coverage remains far below theoretical capability, with most workplace deployments still concentrated on narrow automation rather than on the broader knowledge-work substitution implied by industry projections (Anthropic, 2026; Acemoglu, 2025). These conditions

matter for the present study because they shape the context in which governance discourse is produced: corporate commitments regarding AI-driven transformation may carry different meaning when the actual drivers of workforce reduction are predominantly economic, and when the technology itself is not yet operating at the scale firms invoke to justify their decisions.

1.2.2 AI Governance Principles Research

Within this regulatory vacuum, a proliferation of voluntary governance has filled the space. Jobin et al. (2019) mapped 84 sets of AI ethics guidelines issued by governments, corporations, civil society organizations, and multi-stakeholder groups globally, finding convergence around principles such as transparency, fairness, non-maleficence, responsibility, and privacy, alongside significant divergence in interpretation and enforcement. Floridi et al. (2018) synthesized the normative terrain into five core principles - beneficence, non-maleficence, autonomy, justice, and explicability - providing one of the earliest frameworks for evaluating AI governance quality.

The critique of this voluntary governance is well established. Hagendorff (2020) found that the majority of guidelines lack enforcement mechanisms, functioning as aspirational statements rather than operational commitments. Schultz and Seele (2022) extended the greenwashing concept into the digital domain, modelling "machinewashing" (a term from Wagner, 2018) to describe corporate use of AI ethics discourse to project responsibility while failing to implement substantive safeguards. Schultz et al. (2024) developed this further into an ethicswashing typology distinguishing process, perception, and outcome dimension, establishing that performative ethics is not a firm-level aberration but a systemic feature sustained by policymakers, industry associations, and academics who collectively maintain grey zones in voluntary governance.

The regulatory context reviewed in §1.2.1 explains why this pattern persists. When binding regulation is fragmented internationally and structurally blind to employment relationships at the EU level, voluntary principles face no external accountability pressure. Firms can adopt governance frameworks that converge on similar language and similar structures without any mechanism requiring those frameworks to produce the outcomes they describe. The next section examines what outcomes have in fact materialized.

1.2.3 Workforce Displacement and the Question of Attribution

At the micro level, displacement effects are materializing in the labour market. Brynjolfsson et al. (2025), analysing large-scale US payroll data, document a 16 percent relative employment decline for workers aged 22–25 in AI-exposed occupations since late 2022. Software developers in that age group experienced nearly 20 percent losses from their 2022 peak. The effects concentrate in occupations where AI automates rather than augments human labour and are absent where AI exposure is low (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025). Analysis of labour market survey data, using AI exposure metrics derived from enterprise usage patterns, reveals a 14 percent drop in the job-finding rate for young workers in exposed occupations, with actual AI task coverage still far below theoretical capability (Anthropic, 2026). These declines emerged specifically after late 2022 and do not correspond to earlier economic disruptions, pointing to a genuine AI-linked shift (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025).

At the macro level, the picture is different. Acemoglu (2025), drawing on task-level cost-saving estimates calibrated against pre-2024 occupational task data and pre-generative-AI cost benchmarks, projects that AI will produce no more than a 0.66 percent total increase in factor productivity over ten years, approximately 0.064 percent annually. When adjusted for the difficulty of automating complex, context-dependent tasks, the upper bound drops to 0.53 percent. Only 4.6 percent of all economic tasks can be profitably automated within a decade on this calibration. The calibration window matters: Acemoglu's task-level cost estimates were assembled before the widespread enterprise deployment of large language models documented by Brynjolfsson et al. (2025) and Anthropic (2026), and the macro projection is therefore best read as a lower-bound benchmark against which the more recent micro-level evidence is judged, rather than as a settled forward estimate. These figures contrast sharply with industry projections of 7 percent GDP growth (Goldman Sachs) or 1.5 to 3.4 percentage points of annual GDP growth (McKinsey), which Acemoglu's model shows to be implausible on the basis of task-level cost savings alone. AI is also predicted to widen the gap between capital and labour income (Acemoglu, 2025).

The micro and macro findings are not strictly contradictory: concentrated employment declines among specific worker groups are compatible with modest aggregate cost savings from AI at the task level. Yet the prominence of AI as an explanation for workforce reduction in corporate communications raises questions about how governance frameworks should account for displacement whose causes are multiple and contested. If AI's aggregate economic impact is this limited, the wave of corporate layoffs attributed to AI is unlikely to be primarily technology-driven within a two-year window. This is a thesis-level inference, not a claim Acemoglu makes, and it draws support from two additional sources. First, the economic landscape with conditions such as overhiring, tariffs, demand softening, provides alternative explanations for workforce reductions that overlap temporally with AI adoption. Second, financial market incentives shape how firms communicate these reductions. Eshghi and Astvansh (2024), show that stock investors penalize reactive layoffs (signaling demand decline or financial distress) with an average abnormal return of -1.4 percent, while proactively framed layoffs (signalling efficiency or restructuring) receive no market penalty. Managers face structural incentives to present workforce reductions as strategic transformation. Several firms whose governance documents are examined in Phase 1 of this thesis (including Klarna, Microsoft, Salesforce, IBM, and Accenture) are among those prominently framing recent layoffs as AI-driven (CNBC, 2025), even as independent researchers describe these attributions as scapegoating of economic drivers (Stephany, as cited in CNBC, 2025; Seamans, as cited in Fortune, 2025).

The displacement evidence therefore does not tell a simple story of technology replacing workers. Real but concentrated micro-level effects coexist with modest aggregate impact, economic pressures drive the majority of reductions, and financial incentives reward firms for framing those reductions as AI-driven. The governance frameworks examined in this thesis are produced within precisely these conditions.

1.3. Problem Statement

The gap identified above is not merely an oversight in the literature; it marks a normatively significant tension. Whether the disconnection between governance commitments and workforce outcomes constitutes a failure of organisational responsibility, or a structural feature of how governance functions in competitive markets, remains unexamined.

The significance of this question extends beyond empirical description. Organizations do not operate in a normative vacuum. They function within implicit social contracts - unwritten but binding agreements that constitute the ethical foundation of economic communities (Donaldson & Dunfee, 1999). The employment relationship creates what Donaldson and Dunfee term microsocial contracts: mutual expectations grounded in a specific organisational community. Workers contribute labor and loyalty; employers provide wages, reasonable stability, and consideration during transitions. These microsocial norms carry moral weight, but their legitimacy depends on compatibility with hypernorms - fundamental ethical principles, including respect for human dignity and the obligation not to cause unnecessary harm, that transcend any particular community (Donaldson & Dunfee, 1999).

The ethical weight of the governance-displacement gap is amplified by the organisational context in which it occurs. Van Buren (2000) demonstrated that firms not experiencing declining resource munificence bear the strongest obligation to internalize displacement costs. If resource-rich companies adopt AI to improve margins rather than to ensure organisational survival - a condition this thesis examines empirically - they operate under what Integrative Social Contracts Theory calls the most constrained conditions of managerial moral free space, meaning that their discretion to impose costs on workers is at its narrowest precisely because they possess the resources to bear those costs themselves (Van Buren, 2000). Governance documents produced under such conditions represent claims about microsocial contract fulfillment that may or may not be substantiated by actual organisational practice.

This thesis therefore investigates not only whether a governance-displacement gap exists in corporate AI discourse, but what that gap means for organisational responsibility and social sustainability. The inquiry speaks directly to the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals, in particular SDG 8 (decent work and economic growth) and SDG 16 (peace, justice, and strong institutions): both depend on whether organizations operating under voluntary AI governance honour the social obligations they

declare. The normative implications of this framework are developed further in the Discussion (Chapter 6), after the empirical findings have been presented.

1.4. Aim and Research Questions

The aim of this thesis is to develop understanding of whether corporate AI governance frameworks produce genuine accountability for workforce displacement or function primarily as legitimacy mechanisms. Using Sweden as a most-likely case, where institutional conditions are most favorable for substantive governance, the study examines what the governance–displacement gap reveals about the structural limits of voluntary frameworks. The findings inform organisational leaders, policymakers, and worker representatives whether existing corporate governance mechanisms adequately address displacement risk. Where voluntary governance proves structurally insufficient, the evidence informs collective bargaining priorities and advocacy for binding regulatory safeguards.

Two research questions guide the study, corresponding to the two phases of the research design.

RQ1: *How are AI governance commitments by firms operating in Sweden discursively constructed in the context of AI adoption in responses to workforce displacement?*

The first question examines how firms construct their AI governance commitments (the discursive performance of those commitments across publicly retrievable governance texts) through critical discourse analysis (Fairclough, 1995). It addresses how workforce displacement is framed, acknowledged, or omitted in the language firms use to present their AI commitments, while recognising that governance commitments may also be constituted internally and therefore enter the analysis indirectly via Phase 2.

RQ2: *How do governance practitioners in Swedish AI-adopting firms experience the relationship between AI governance commitments and workforce displacement outcomes?*

The second question examines what practitioners observe from inside organizations, through semi-structured interviews with Human Resources managers and Union representatives. HR managers are the primary register, occupying the operational intersection of governance and displacement: they implement workforce restructuring while communicating commitments to responsible practice. Union representatives provide an employee-protection counter-register, voicing restructuring as experienced rather than enacted. Together their perspectives capture the lived tension between espoused governance and enacted displacement in a way more strategically positioned (e.g., C-suite) or technically oriented roles cannot, enabling comparison between espoused commitments and reported organisational practice

The two phases proceed in a sequenced design whose specifics are set out in Chapter 3; the tentative formulation reflects a pragmatist recognition that research questions in qualitative inquiry are refined as the analytical work shows what the data can and cannot warrant (see §3.1; Braun & Clarke, 2006).

1.5. Layout

The thesis proceeds as follows. Chapter 2 develops the analytical framework: institutional isomorphism, legitimacy theory, and externality theory, synthesised into a single lens. Chapter 3 sets out the two-phase qualitative design (Critical Discourse Analysis of governance texts, followed by Reflexive Thematic Analysis of practitioner interviews) and presents the firms and Swedish AI governance context. Chapters 5 and 6 then apply the framework to the data and discuss what the findings mean for organisational responsibility, with limitations and directions for further inquiry.

2. Theoretical Foundation

If I have seen further it is by standing on the shoulders of Giants.
Isaac Newton[2]

The previous chapter documented a gap between corporate AI governance commitments and workforce displacement outcomes, situated within a regulatory architecture that leaves workers largely unprotected and economic conditions that complicate causal attribution. This chapter provides the theoretical framework for analyzing that gap. The framework is assembled from a pragmatist standpoint: theories are treated as analytical instruments selected for their explanatory traction on a concrete problem rather than as expressions of a single deductive system (Dewey, 1938; James, 1907). Three theories, each operating at a different level of explanation, structure the analysis. Institutional isomorphism (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983) explains why governance frameworks converge across firms. Legitimacy theory (Suchman, 1995) explains what motivates their adoption. Externality theory (Pigou, 1932) explains why the resulting governance is structurally insufficient to address the costs it claims to manage. Each theory is applied in the critical discourse analysis as a distinct analytical dimension, detailed in the Methodology chapter (Chapter 3). The chapter closes with an analytical framework that synthesizes the three pillars and anchors them to the normative stakes of the research through Integrative Social Contracts Theory (Donaldson & Dunfee, 1999).

2.1. Pillar 1: Institutional Isomorphism and the Observable Pattern

The first analytical pillar addresses the observable pattern: why do corporate AI governance frameworks converge across firms, adopting similar principles, structures, and language regardless of their specific operational contexts?

DiMaggio and Powell (1983) argued that once an organisational field becomes established, powerful forces drive organizations toward structural homogeneity - not because convergence improves performance, but because it confers legitimacy. Their argument rests on a key insight about organisational fields: as fields mature through increased interaction among organizations, the emergence of inter-organisational structures, increased information load, and mutual awareness among participants, they develop shared cognitive frames and normative expectations that constrain the range of legitimate organisational responses. Within this process of field structuration, three mechanisms produce isomorphic pressure. Coercive isomorphism arises from political influence and the problem of legitimacy: organizations adopt structures and practices in response to regulatory mandates, industry standards, and the expectations of powerful actors including the state - on whom they depend for resources and authorization. Mimetic isomorphism operates under conditions of uncertainty: when goals are ambiguous or technologies are poorly understood, organizations model themselves on peers perceived as successful or legitimate, not because imitation is efficient but because it reduces the cognitive burden of responding to ambiguity. Normative isomorphism results from professionalization: shared educational backgrounds, professional networks, and the circulation of personnel across organizations create common cognitive frames and standard operating approaches that are carried into new organisational contexts.

Critically, DiMaggio and Powell (1983) argued that these isomorphic processes operate independently of whether the adopted practices are effective at achieving their stated goals. Organizations adopt structures because other organizations have adopted them, because powerful actors expect them, or because professional norms dictate them. Once adoption exceeds a certain threshold within a field, the practice becomes institutionalized: it provides legitimacy rather than performance improvements, and organizations that fail to adopt face questions about their rationality or trustworthiness. The implications for governance are significant: isomorphism predicts that the convergence of governance forms across organizations says nothing about whether those forms produce the outcomes they claim to address.

Application to AI Governance

[2] Isaac Newton, letter to Robert Hooke, 5 February 1675.

The rapid proliferation of AI ethics frameworks across firms can be understood as an isomorphic process. Under conditions of profound technological uncertainty, AI's societal effects are ambiguous, rapidly evolving, and poorly understood - firms model their governance responses on industry peers (mimetic isomorphism). Regulatory signals such as the EU AI Act and CSRD create coercive pressures toward governance adoption. Standards disseminated through professional networks, consultancies, and industry associations produce normative convergence. The result is convergence in governance form: similar principles, similar structures, similar language - regardless of whether these frameworks produce different outcomes for different firms or their workforces.

For this thesis, isomorphism explains why governance frameworks look similar across the studied firms. The convergence and divergence patterns that emerge feed directly into the isomorphism analysis: textual similarity, shared vocabulary, and structural parallels that indicate imitation rather than context-specific design.

2.2. Pillar 2: Legitimacy Theory and the Motivation

The second analytical pillar addresses the motivation: why do firms adopt AI governance frameworks? If isomorphism explains the convergence pattern, legitimacy theory explains the organisational incentive driving it.

Suchman (1995) defined organisational legitimacy as a generalised perception or assumption that the actions of an entity are desirable, proper, or appropriate within a given system of norms, values, beliefs, and definitions. He distinguished three types. Pragmatic legitimacy rests on the self-interested calculations of an organisation's most immediate audience - legitimacy earned through exchange, influence, or responsiveness to stakeholders' practical needs; on the pragmatist reading adopted in this thesis, this is the form of legitimacy that most directly orients itself to workable consequences for the actors involved. Moral legitimacy reflects a positive normative evaluation of the organisation and its activities - whether the organisation is perceived to be doing "the right thing." Cognitive legitimacy operates at a deeper level: taken-for-grantedness, the degree to which an organisation's existence and activities are perceived as natural, necessary, and comprehensible rather than requiring active justification. A long-standing strand of institutional theory - Meyer and Rowan (1977) - identifies the structural complement to legitimacy management: organisations that secure legitimacy through formal conformity can decouple their formal structures from their operational practices, sustaining the appearance of conformity without altering underlying conduct. Suchman (1995) cites Meyer and Rowan among the foundational sources for the legitimacy-as-symbolic-conformity strand his framework formalises.

Suchman (1995) further distinguished between gaining, maintaining, and repairing legitimacy - three phases with distinct strategic implications. Organizations seeking to gain legitimacy must actively conform to existing norms or manipulate their environment to create new legitimating beliefs. Critically, Suchman noted that in gaining moral legitimacy, organizations may employ carefully chosen symbolic displays that circumvent the need for substantive change - at the extreme, managers can revise core mission statements and governance commitments to create a false appearance of conformity to societal ideals, maintaining the perception of alignment without altering underlying practices. Organizations seeking to maintain legitimacy must monitor their environment for emerging threats and stockpile supportive perceptions. Organizations seeking to repair legitimacy after a crisis face the most acute pressures and may resort to normalizing accounts and strategic restructuring. Across all three phases, the analytical implication is consistent: legitimacy management can substitute symbolic action for substantive organisational change.

Application to AI Governance

AI governance frameworks function as legitimacy instruments. By publishing ethical AI principles, firms signal moral legitimacy - that they are "doing the right thing" regarding AI's societal impacts. They construct cognitive legitimacy by making their AI practices appear comprehensible and predictable to stakeholders: regulators, employees, the public, and investors. The gain/maintain/repair distinction is analytically relevant here: firms that published AI ethics frameworks before public scrutiny intensified may have been gaining or maintaining legitimacy proactively, while firms that published frameworks after high-profile controversies - layoffs, bias incidents, regulatory pressure - may be

engaged in legitimacy repair, which Suchman's framework predicts is more likely to rely on symbolic rather than substantive responses. In either case, the framework warns that legitimacy-seeking can be decoupled from substantive action: organizations may produce governance documents that secure the perception of responsibility without requiring the organisational changes that genuine responsibility would entail.

For this thesis, legitimacy theory explains why firms produce governance documents and provides the analytical basis for distinguishing between genuine and performative governance. Schultz et al.'s (2024) ethicswashing typology: distinct from Schultz and Seele's (2022) earlier machinewashing concept though building on its foundations, articulates this distinction along three dimensions. The process dimension examines ethicswashing as a social construction involving multiple actors beyond the firm - including policymakers, industry associations, and academia - who collectively contribute to grey zones in voluntary governance. The perception dimension assesses whether corporate communications are experienced as genuine or as a facade: a mismatch between stated commitments and observable organisational practice. The outcome dimension examines consequences at two levels: internal effects on firm capabilities and employee engagement, and external effects including regulatory avoidance and erosion of public trust. The typology connects explicitly to legitimacy theory: ethicswashing is instrumental legitimacy-seeking through misleading ethical compliance.

2.3. Pilar 3: Externality Theory and the Structural Trap

The third analytical pillar addresses the structural question: even when organizations recognize the gap between governance commitments and workforce outcomes, why does the gap persist? Externality theory provides a structural explanation rooted in the economics of cost and benefit allocation.

Pigou (1932) established that a transaction generates an externality whenever one party, in the course of rendering services for which payment is received, incidentally imposes uncompensated costs on third-party persons (people who did not agree to the transaction and from whom compensation cannot practically be exacted). The constitutive feature of a Pigovian externality is therefore the existence of a person (or institutional welfare third-party) outside the contractual web of the transaction who bears a cost no one is paying for. Capital-allocation choices internal to the firm-shareholder relationship (how a firm distributes returns between equity-holders and other firm-controlled spending categories) are not externalities in this sense; they redistribute value within the transacting parties rather than imposing costs on third parties. Pigou's analytical move was to separate the private return captured by the contracting parties from the broader social effect, which includes the uncompensated burden on those third parties. When the two diverge, individually rational decisions produce collectively suboptimal outcomes. Pigou's remedy followed from the diagnosis: because competitive markets cannot self-correct this divergence, external intervention (through taxation, regulation, or equivalent collective mechanisms) is required to internalise the third-party cost. Without such intervention, the parties generating these externalities have no structural incentive to absorb them.

The framework also recognises two further classical cases. A firm may generate a positive externality whose benefit flows uncompensated to third parties (the classical positive-production case, addressed historically through subsidy to encourage production where the social return exceeds the private one (Pigou, 1932)). A firm may also draw on third-party resources (public infrastructure, accumulated collective knowledge, shared inputs) without commensurate compensation flowing back, blurring the boundary between the captured-value case discussed above and a parallel input-side externality. Both share the constitutive feature already named: a third party materially implicated in the firm's accounting without a contract acknowledging that fact.

Extending the framework into the contemporary value-capture critique (Mazzucato, 2018), a fourth case completes the analytical landscape. When a private actor captures a benefit whose generation depended on contributions from third parties (public infrastructure, accumulated collective knowledge, or the labour of those whose practice the activity now replicates or displaces), the benefit is externalised in its origin even as it is internalised in its private capture. The third party sits outside the contractual web yet is materially implicated in the value at stake, and no compensation flows back. Where the classical cases call for taxation to internalise the unpaid cost or subsidy to internalise the underprovided benefit, this contemporary case calls for collective claim on the captured value (through redistribution, public

licensing, or equivalent mechanisms). Across all four cases (cost imposed outward, benefit conferred outward, cost extracted inward, benefit captured inward), the analytical move is the same: read past the accounting of the transacting parties to see who, beyond that surface, either bears a cost or supplied a value that no contract acknowledges.

Application to AI Governance

AI-driven workforce displacement generates externalities in precisely this sense. Firms deploying AI capture efficiency gains and cost savings - the firm-side internal benefit - while the uncompensated costs (lost wages, lost benefits, transition costs, foregone career-progression, community disruption) fall on third-party people who did not agree to the transaction: displaced workers, workers in supply chains and adjacent labour markets, and the public welfare systems that absorb the residual. Corporate AI governance frameworks can be understood as partial internalisation mechanisms: attempts, whether genuine or symbolic, to close this gap by acknowledging and addressing the costs of AI deployment that would otherwise fall on those third parties.

But externality theory predicts that competitive dynamics constrain internalization. Firms that unilaterally absorb displacement costs - through retraining programs, extended severance, transition support, or slower deployment timelines - face competitive disadvantage relative to firms that do not. This structural incentive makes symbolic compliance economically rational: appearing to internalize costs through governance discourse (maintaining legitimacy) while externalizing the actual costs (maintaining competitive position). The resulting gap is not a failure of design or commitment but a structurally rational equilibrium: governance that appears responsive to social costs while the market rewards their displacement. Without regulation, collective bargaining, or enforceable standards that impose equivalent costs on all competitors, voluntary governance cannot replicate the Pigouvian correction it substitutes for.

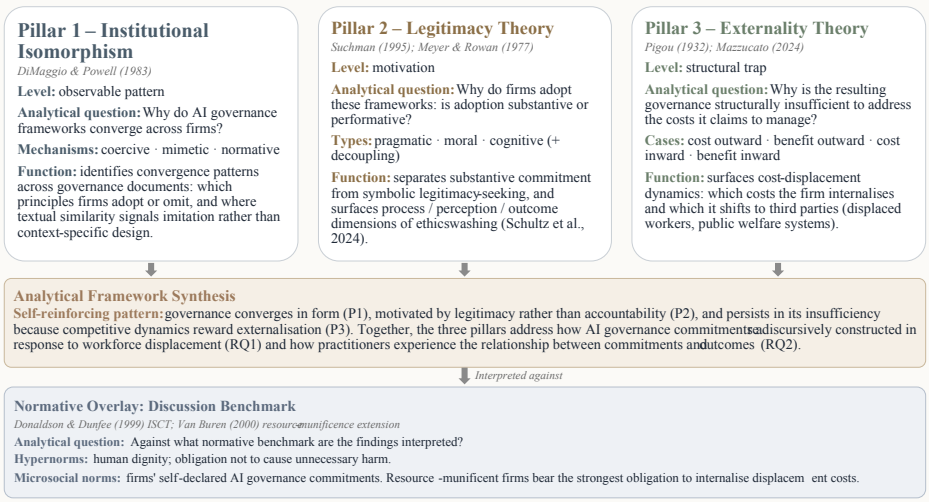
2.4. Analytical Framework Synthesis

The three analytical pillars operate as a causal sequence - not because the theories were designed to work together, but because the research problem requires explanations at three different levels that these theories, in combination, provide. Institutional isomorphism explains the observable convergence of AI governance frameworks: under conditions of technological uncertainty, coercive, mimetic, and normative pressures drive organizations toward structurally similar governance responses regardless of whether those responses are effective. Legitimacy theory explains why firms adopt these frameworks: governance documents serve as instruments for securing moral and cognitive legitimacy, creating organisational incentives for symbolic displays that may substitute for substantive change. Externality theory explains why the resulting governance is structurally insufficient: competitive dynamics penalize firms that unilaterally internalize displacement costs, making symbolic compliance the economically rational response while genuine internalization remains structurally disadvantaged. Together, the three pillars describe a self-reinforcing pattern in which governance converges in form, is motivated by legitimacy rather than accountability, and persists in its insufficiency because the market rewards cost externalization.

The significance of this structural pattern extends beyond institutional behavior. Drawing on Integrative Social Contracts Theory, Donaldson and Dunfee (1999) argued that economic actors operate within a web of social contracts at two levels: macrosocial hypernorms - fundamental principles such as human dignity and the obligation not to cause unnecessary harm - that set ethical boundaries across all communities, and microsocial norms generated within specific organisational and industry contexts. Corporate AI governance documents can be understood as firms' self-declared microsocial contracts: voluntary normative commitments against which their own practices can be assessed. These microsocial norms are legitimate only insofar as they are compatible with hypernorms. Van Buren (2000) extended this framework specifically to workforce displacement, demonstrating that the ethical weight of organisational decisions to reduce employment is contingent on resource munificence: firms not facing declining resources bear the strongest obligation to internalize displacement costs, because their moral free space is most constrained when they possess the capacity to act otherwise. The firms examined in this thesis are predominantly resource-rich firms, placing them in the most ethically constrained conditions of Van Buren's framework. ISCT is not operationalized as a coding tool in the Phase 1 CDA

- it does not generate analytical categories - but establishes the normative benchmark against which the Discussion chapter interprets the findings produced by the three analytical pillars (see Figure 2.1).

Figure 2.1 Analytical Framework: Three-Pillar Diagram with Normative Overlay



In the analysis, each pillar performs a distinct explanatory function. Isomorphism identifies convergence patterns across governance documents - what principles firms adopt, which they omit, and how textual similarity signals imitation rather than context-specific design. Legitimacy theory distinguishes genuine from performative governance measures by separating substantive commitment from symbolic legitimacy-seeking, surfacing the process-, perception-, and outcome-level dimensions along which performative governance presents itself. Externality theory surfaces cost-displacement dynamics - directing attention to where governance language reveals which costs are internalised by the firm and which are shifted to third-party people. Together, the three pillars address the first research question: how are AI governance commitments discursively constructed in responses to workforce displacement? The second research question - how do governance practitioners experience the relationship between commitments and outcomes? - extends the framework from textual analysis into lived organisational practice, asking whether the patterns the framework predicts find traction in practitioners' reported experiences or surface tensions that warrant revision.

3. Methodology

The function of inquiry is to transform an indeterminate situation into one that is so determinate in its constituent distinctions and relations as to convert the elements of the original situation into a unified whole.

Dewey[3]

This chapter sets out the pragmatist positioning, the two-phase qualitative design, the analytical procedures for each phase, and the strategies for trustworthiness and ethical conduct.

3.1. Philosophical Positioning

This study adopts a pragmatist perspective on knowledge production. Pragmatism, in the tradition of Dewey (1938) and developed for inquiry by Morgan (2014) and Kaushik and Walsh (2019), treats research as a form of disciplined practical reasoning: the test of a method or a concept is whether it does useful analytical work on the problem at hand, not whether it satisfies a prior metaphysical commitment to either an objective reality or a purely constructed one. Knowledge claims are warranted by the evidence they help organise and by the consequences they support, rather than by their fit with a single ontological doctrine. Multiple perspectives (corporate documents, practitioner accounts, and union accounts) are treated as legitimate sources of evidence about the same domain of practice; where they converge, the claim is strengthened, and where they diverge, the divergence itself becomes analytically informative (Kaushik & Walsh, 2019).

Interpretation is inevitably shaped by personal and cultural backgrounds (Silverman, 2014). Both authors are non-Swedish researchers examining a Swedish institutional context, which positions them as outsiders with respect to the labour market norms and collective bargaining traditions that characterise the empirical setting. Such outsider positioning carries both risks: culturally embedded assumptions may be overlooked - and advantages - taken-for-granted institutional logics may be more visible to researchers who do not share them. Reflexivity is practised as a continuous process throughout data collection and analysis.

3.2. Research Design

The study employs a two-phase qualitative design in which Phase 1 sequentially informs Phase 2. Phase 1 applies Critical Discourse Analysis to a corpus of governance-relevant texts. Phase 2 conducts semi-structured interviews with governance practitioners, analysed via Reflexive Thematic Analysis. Both phases address the same phenomenon from complementary angles: documents reveal how firms discursively construct their governance stance, while interviews reveal how practitioners experience the governance-displacement tension. The sequence is logical rather than strictly serial. Phase 1 analytical observations refined the Phase 2 interview probes, particularly in the cost-allocation and ethicswashing clusters, while document preparation, and analytical reading proceeded in parallel where doing so did not displace the informing direction. The logic of inquiry is abductive throughout, moving iteratively between the three-pillar framework introduced in Chapter 2 and the patterns emerging from both data sources.

Under this sequenced design, the two sets of findings are integrated in the Discussion chapter, where discursive patterns identified in governance documents are read against practitioner accounts. Convergence between HR interviews and published documents alone cannot validate a finding because practitioners may reproduce the legitimacy register their employer constructs. Two design choices mitigate this risk. First, Phase 2 probes push past the documentary register into cost-bearing and silence-on-AI-displacement territory. Second, recruitment extends to Union representatives, whose counter-register accounts provide an independent check. Where document discourse, HR accounts, and Union accounts diverge across the three registers, the divergence is itself a core finding (see Ch5 §5.5; Ch6 §6.1.1). (> §6.1)

[3] Dewey, J. (1938). Logic: The Theory of Inquiry. Henry Holt, pp. 104–105.

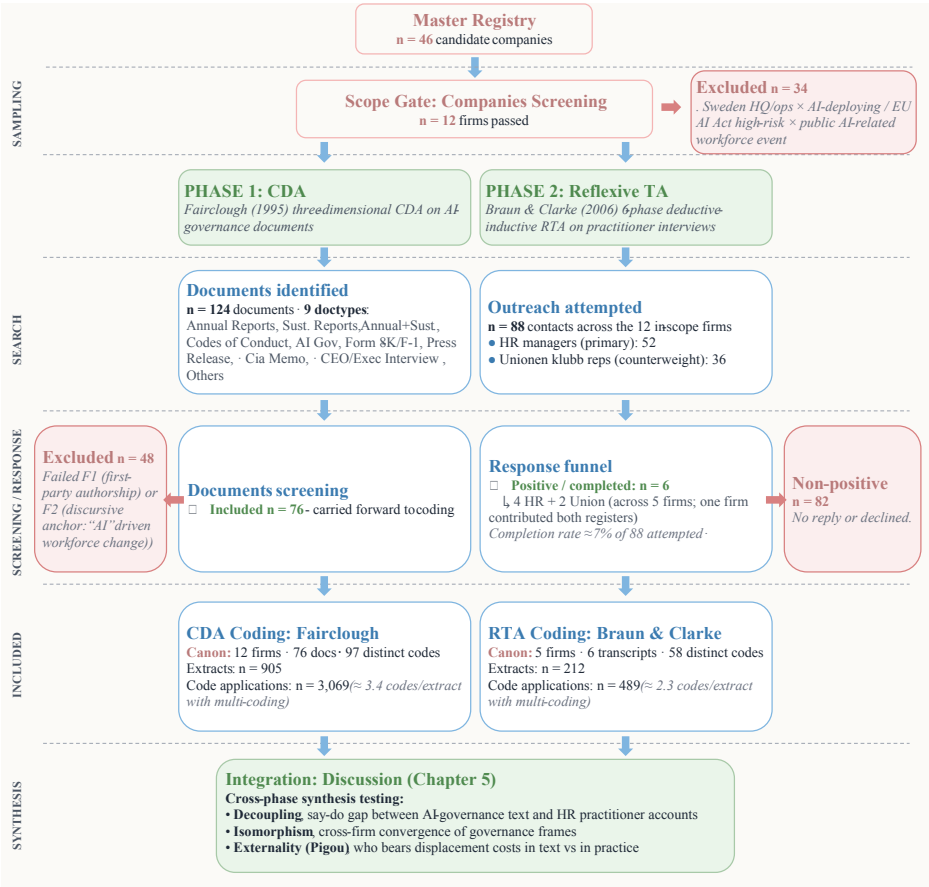
Situating the study within the Swedish institutional context follows a most-likely case logic (Flyvbjerg, 2006). Sweden's strong institutional environment, characterised by high unionisation rates, comprehensive collective bargaining coverage, and progressive regulatory frameworks including the EU AI Act and CSRD - represents conditions under which substantive AI governance is most likely to emerge. If governance frameworks fail to produce meaningful accountability for workforce displacement even in this favourable setting, the finding suggests that the gap is structural rather than contextual.

Table 3.1 Methodology Overview

Level	Phase 1 - CDA	Phase 2 - Reflexive TA
Paradigm	Pragmatism (Dewey 1938; Morgan 2014; Kaushik & Walsh 2019): knowledge claims are warranted by the analytical work they support, not by metaphysical commitment to a single ontology. Abductive logic throughout.	
Design	Two-phase qualitative. Sequenced (Phase 1 findings refine Phase 2 probes). Sweden as most-likely case (Flyvbjerg 2006). Multi-source: documents + HR + Union	
Research question	RQ1: How are AI governance commitments by firms operating in Sweden discursively constructed in the context of AI adoption in responses to workforce displacement?	RQ2: How do governance practitioners in Swedish AI-adopting firms experience the relationship between AI governance commitments and workforce displacement outcomes?
Method	Fairclough (1995) three-dimensional Critical Discourse Analysis	Braun & Clarke (2006, 2019) Reflexive Thematic Analysis - latent-level, abductive (deductive + inductive)
Empirical object	Publicly retrievable AI-governance documents (firms publicly identifiable; no anonymisation at Phase 1)	Semi-structured practitioner interviews (anonymised in all outputs)
Sampling unit	Firm	Practitioner
Analytical unit	Document	Transcript
Coding unit	Paragraph (multi-code permitted)	Extract (multi-code permitted)
Codebook architecture	**Four layers:** D1 Textual · D2 Discursive practice · D3 Sociocultural practice (isomorphism, legitimacy, ethicswashing) · D4 Pigou allocative layer (welfare-economics complement to D3, not a fourth Fairclough dimension)	**Deductive anchors carried from Phase 1**: D3 + D4 only. D1 and D2 not applied (designed for written governance text - importing them into spoken-account analysis would create paradigm incoherence). Plus inductive emergent codes per Braun & Clarke's reflexive process.
Corpus / sampling logic	Five structural inclusion criteria + EU AI Act exposure as sensitising criterion · cross-industry by design (isomorphism operates at field level, not within industry) · four genre families to expose intertextuality	HR (primary register) + Union representatives (counter-register design)
Output → Discussion	Discursive patterns per firm	Themes anchored across transcripts (anti-anecdotalism rule)
	Allocative Synthesis: Pigou Framework (Costs/Benefits x Externalized/Internalized)	

The procedural realisation of this design - how the candidate pool was screened down to the analysed corpus in each phase - is shown in Figure below.

Figure 3.1 Research Process: PRISMA-style Flow



3.3. Phase 1: Critical Discourse Analysis

Phase 1 applies Fairclough's (1995) three-dimensional Critical Discourse Analysis framework to answer the first research question: how AI governance commitments are discursively constructed in the context of AI adoption in responses to workforce displacement at firms operating in Sweden, as evidenced in publicly retrievable documents. The framework treats any discursive event as analysable simultaneously at three levels - text, discursive practice, and sociocultural practice - and treats those levels as dialectically related, with discursive practice mediating between linguistic form and social context. CDA is selected over content analysis because the research question asks how governance discourse constructs the relationship between AI adoption and workforce outcomes, not how often particular terms appear.

3.3.1 Document Selection and Sampling

The corpus consists of governance-relevant documents produced by Swedish AI-adopting firms. The firm is the sampling unit and the document is the analytical unit. Structural criteria identify which firms enter the corpus, while genre diversity within each firm captures how governance discourse circulates across audiences.

The corpus unit is operationalised as any governance-relevant text that publicly evidences a firm's AI governance commitments, including standalone AI principles documents, policy pages, codes of

business conduct, sustainability and annual reports, SEC filings, press releases, and on-record executive interviews. AI governance commitments may also be constituted internally[4] and these internally-constituted commitments are approached indirectly via Phase 2 practitioner accounts rather than directly through the Phase 1 corpus.

Five structural criteria governed corpus inclusion:

Table 3.2 Corpus inclusion criteria

Criterion	Operationalisation
Operational presence in Sweden	Headquarters, regional headquarters, or substantive Swedish subsidiary.
Organisational scale	Capable of producing formal AI governance discourse: Fortune 500, multinational, large corporate, or Swedish-local firm with dedicated governance-reporting infrastructure.
AI adoption	Publicly identifiable as deploying AI in operational or workforce-relevant domains.
Document availability	At least one publicly available governance-relevant document.
EU AI Act exposure	Sensitising criterion (high-risk, limited, or potentially high-risk) surfacing coercive isomorphic pressure; not an exclusion filter.

Note. Headquarters nationality was not an inclusion criterion; operational presence in Sweden was.

Applying these criteria to an initial search pool of 46 firms with operational presence in Sweden and identifiable AI-adoption signals (drawn from public registers, sector mapping, and AI-deployment indicators) yielded the twelve firms that entered Phase 1 (see Figure 3.2).

Table 3.3 Firm corpus qualifiers across the twelve in-scope firms

Firm	Headquarters	Sweden presence	Industry	Scale	EU AI Act exposure	AI-related layoff
Accenture	Ireland	Subsidiary	Professional services	Fortune 500	High-risk	AI-related
British American Tobacco	United Kingdom	Subsidiary	Tobacco / FMCG	Fortune 500	Limited	AI-related
Electrolux Group	Sweden	HQ	Consumer appliances	Fortune 500	Limited	Non-AI
Google (Alphabet)	United States	Subsidiary	Technology / Internet	Fortune 500	High-risk	AI-related
IBM	United States	Subsidiary	Technology / IT services	Fortune 500	High-risk	AI-related
IKEA (Ingka)	Netherlands (Swedish-rooted)	HQ	Retail / Furnishings	Multinational corporation	Limited	Non-AI
Klarna	Sweden	HQ	Fintech / BNPL	Large corporate	High-risk	AI-related
Länsförsäkringar	Sweden	HQ	Insurance / Banking	Large corporate	High-risk	No significant
Microsoft	United States	Subsidiary	Technology / Software	Fortune 500	High-risk	AI-related
Nordea	Finland (Swedish-Finnish)	Subsidiary	Banking	Multinational corporation	High-risk	AI-related

Deleted: ¶

SAP	Germany	Subsidiary	Technology / ERP	Fortune 500	High-risk	AI-related
Salesforce	United States	Subsidiary	Technology / CRM	Fortune 500	High-risk	AI-related

Note: A detailed per-firm corpus briefs can be seen in Appendix B

Cross-industry composition is deliberate. Institutional isomorphism operates at the organisational field level rather than within a single industry (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983), and a single-industry sample would confound isomorphic pressure with industry-specific norms.

AI-attributed workforce reduction was considered as a relevance filter but then rejected. Layoff-attribution is itself a discursive move that firms exercise discretion over (see §1.2.3), and filtering on visible attribution would have under-sampled firms whose governance discourse engages in structural silence about AI displacement (> §1.1): the most theoretically informative configuration for the cost-allocation analysis. The relevance condition is therefore AI-displacement phenomenon-relevance, with layoff trajectory retained as context indicator.

Within each in-scope firm, governance-relevant documents were collected across as many genres as the firm publicly produced. Multi-genre coverage is analytical leverage rather than redundancy. Fairclough's (1995) framework treats genre and intertextuality as the discursive-practice layer mediating between text and sociocultural practice, and a single-genre corpus would suppress this analytical dimension. Where a firm has documented AI-related workforce events, the corpus deliberately retrieves multiple genre instances around these events, enabling analysis of how the same governance event is reframed as it moves across audiences with different intertextual conventions and modal registers.

The final corpus comprises 76 documents across the twelve firms, generating 905 unique coded extracts. Per-firm document counts reflect differences in public availability and the maturity of each firm's governance-reporting infrastructure.

Table 3.4 Phase 1 coding-volume distribution across the twelve firms

Firm	# documents	Coding rows	Extracts
SAP	8	277	58
Microsoft	9	263	73
Salesforce	6	208	56
Klarna	7	184	57
IKEA (Ingka)	5	170	170
British American Tobacco	6	169	53
Accenture	5	166	38
IBM	6	158	58
Google	5	134	37
Nordea	4	114	27
Electrolux Group	3	67	23
Länsförsäkringar	3	55	18
Corpus total	67	1,976	668

The corpus collects documents across four genre families: standalone AI governance texts (AI principles, Responsible AI frameworks, AI ethics policies); integrated firm-level reporting (annual, sustainability, integrated, ESG); codes of business conduct; and ad-hoc disclosure (SEC filings, press releases, CEO memos, executive interviews).

Two firms (IKEA Ingka and Länsförsäkringar) operate a Category 2 governance paradigm in which substantive internal AI governance is not consolidated into public-facing artefacts; the smaller public document footprint reflects publication strategy rather than governance absence (see Ch5 §5.2.3).

The corpus spans 2018 to 2025. The earliest text is the 2018 Google AI Principles; the latest documents include 2024 and 2025 ESG, sustainability, and AI Transparency reports. Mass-layoff disclosure events that fall within the corpus window cluster in 2023, 2024, and 2025.

Phase 1 firms and documents are publicly identifiable, no anonymization is applied at this phase. Phase 2 interview participants are drawn from firms within the Phase 1 corpus, but not every Phase 1 firm contributes a Phase 2 interviewee, preserving the phenomenon-focused framing that governs both phases.

3.3.2 Analytical Procedure

The corpus is analyzed through a structured codebook that maps each code family explicitly to one of Fairclough's three dimensions, with a fourth grouping added as a welfare-economics complement to the sociocultural level rather than as an extension of the Fairclough framework itself. Genre is analyzed at the document level and feeds the intertextuality codes at the discursive-practice level.

Table 3.5 Codebook architecture mapped to Fairclough's three-dimensional framework

Dimension	Code family	Short description
D1: Textual (form-and-meaning analysis of language)	D1.1 LEXICAL-Displacement	Captures how documents name workforce reduction: direct terms, euphemism, reskilling framing, or naturalizing language.
	D1.2 LEXICAL - Responsibility	Identifies who is positioned as the agent of workforce change: firm, industry, society, technology, or worker.
	D1.3 LEXICAL - Worker	Distinguishes personal, instrumentalizing, and depersonalizing terms for workers.
	D1.4 Transitivity	Clause-level agency mapping: passive constructions, nominalizations, and assigned grammatical actor (technology, firm, worker, or none).
	D1.5 Modality	Commitment strength of statements: strong, aspirational, hedged, or stated as principle without action verb.
	D1.6 Presupposition	Naturalized assumptions embedded in claims: inevitability, current direction's correctness, scale-superiority, service-improvement framing, shared ideological ground.
	D1.7 Absence	Textual absences treated as positive findings: omitted cost-bearer, decision-maker, alternatives, worker voice, local-scope reference, profitability context, community impact.
D2: Discursive practice (mediating layer)	D2.1 Intertextuality	References to other texts: regulation, industry coalitions, prior firm policy, and covert (uncited) framing borrowed from external discourse.
	D2.3 Interdiscursivity	Blending of innovation, risk, CSR, HR, and legal discourses within a single document.
D3: Sociocultural practice (theory-applied)	D3.1 Isomorphism (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983)	Mimetic, normative, and coercive pressures shaping firm-level governance language.
	D3.2 Legitimacy (Suchman, 1995)	Pragmatic, moral, cognitive, maintenance, and repair forms of legitimacy claim.
	D3.3 Ethicswashing (Schultz et al., 2024)	Process, perception, and outcome claims operating without verification mechanism.
D4: Pigou Allocative Layer (welfare-economics complement to D3, not a fourth	D4.1 PIG-cost-internalize (5 codes)	Severance, reskilling, redeployment, pacing, and acknowledged-but-uncommitted costs - costs the firm names and absorbs.
	D4.2 PIG-cost-externalize (5 codes)	Worker, public-sector, and societal cost-displacement, plus structural silence and naturalising framing - costs shifted from the firm.

Fairclough dimension)	D4.3 PIG-benefit-internalize (5 codes)	Efficiency, margin, operating leverage, competitive position, and strategic capability - benefits the firm captures.
	D4.4 PIG-benefit-externalize (3 codes)	Innovation-ecosystem, broader-economy skilling, and customer-benefit framing - spillover benefits accruing beyond the firm.

The unit of analysis is the paragraph rather than the sentence. Paragraph-level coding preserves clause-level cohesion and latent content that sentence-level segmentation would strip out, which matters in particular for the discursive features captured at D1, since transitivity, modality, and presupposition operate across rather than within sentences (Saunders et al., 2023). One paragraph may carry multiple codes across the four dimensions simultaneously: a single passage might receive a displacement-vocabulary code at D1, an intertextual-reference code at D2, a legitimacy code at D3, and a Pigou cost-externalisation code at D4.

3.4. Phase 2: Reflexive Thematic Analysis

Phase 2 addresses RQ2 through semi-structured interviews with HR practitioners and Union representatives at Swedish AI-adopting firms. The analysis using Braun and Clarke's (2006; 2019) Reflexive Thematic Analysis at the latent level, with a deductive-inductive (abductive) orientation. Deductive anchors carry forward from the Phase 1 D3 and D4 layers (see Table 3.5). The analysis remains open to inductively emergent codes.

3.4.1 Interview Design and Sampling

Participants are recruited through purposive sampling via personal and professional networks. HR practitioners are the primary target group, as they sit at the intersection of hiring and firing decisions and the governance frameworks that ostensibly guide those decisions. Union representatives are recruited as a secondary, counter-register group whose accounts of restructuring speak from the employee-protection position. All participants are drawn from companies within the Phase 1 corpus.

Interviews are semi-structured and phenomenon-focused. The semi-structured form is selected for in-depth exploration of practitioner meaning-making while preserving sufficient structure for cross-case comparison (Braun & Clarke, 2019; Saunders et al., 2023). The phenomenon-focused framing invites participants to reflect on the broader tension between AI governance and workforce displacement within their professional experience, rather than on the specific policies of their employer. This reduces participant sensitivity and enables cross-firm recruitment without company-level access agreements.

The interview protocol distinguishes an HR-manager version from a Union-representative version, reflecting the counter-register design articulated in section 3.2. Both versions open with biographical and role context, move into AI deployment in the participant's organisation and recall of governance commitments and restructuring decisions, and close with probes on cost-bearing framing and on the register divergence between HR and Union accounts. The HR-manager version pushes harder on the operational-implementation layer; the Union-representative version pushes harder on the employee-protection layer. Both versions are reproduced in Appendix A (Interview Guides).

Sample adequacy is judged against the construction of rich, coherent themes that address RQ2 (Braun & Clarke, 2019), rather than against a numerical threshold. Drawing on Braun and Clarke's (2006) fifteen-point quality checklist, the researchers developed an anti-anecdotalism rule requiring every theme to anchor across multiple transcripts and to survive a deliberate hunt for counter-cases.

Six transcripts make up the realised Phase 2 corpus (see Figure 3.2).[5] Recording, transcription, and consent procedures followed the bilingual consent protocol detailed in §3.6; identifying details have been removed from extracts presented in subsequent chapters.

[5] Five interviews were recorded with participant consent and transcribed verbatim. For the interview that consent was not granted, contemporaneous notes were taken instead and worked up into a structured account immediately following the interview.

One HR practitioner and one Union representative in the realised corpus were drawn from the same firm; that pairing was preserved by design to allow practitioner and labour-representative registers to be read from within the same firm-discursive context.

3.4.2 Analytical Procedure

The interview corpus is analysed using Reflexive Thematic Analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006, 2019), conducted at the latent level with an abductive (deductive–inductive) orientation. RTA is suitable for RQ2 because the research question turns on how practitioners experience the relationship between governance commitments and displacement outcomes, a question whose answer lies in the assumptions, naturalised framings, and silences shaping their accounts rather than in surface content (Braun & Clarke, 2006). RTA's theoretical flexibility also permits explicit declaration of paradigmatic positioning, and the abductive orientation allows Phase 1 sensitising concepts to carry forward as domains of attention without becoming a pre-built template, which would convert the analysis into coding and undermine reflexive engagement (Braun & Clarke, 2019; Saunders et al., 2023).

The codebook architecture inherits D3 (Sociocultural) and D4 (Pigou Allocative) from Phase 1 as deductive anchors and operates an emergent stream open from the first transcript. D1 (Textual) and D2 (Discursive practice) are not imported because they were designed for written governance text and would create paradigm incoherence in spoken-account analysis. Two indutive code families consolidated with sufficient cross-transcript anchoring to be formalised.

Table 3.6 Phase 2 RTA codebook architecture: inherited D3/D4 layers extended by inductive emergent codes

Dimension	Code family	Short description
D3: Sociocultural practice (theory-applied; inherited from Phase 1)	D3.1 Isomorphism; D3.2 Legitimacy; D3.3 Ethicswashing	Carried forward and applied to practitioner talk to surface where HR and union accounts reproduce, contest, or normalise field-level pressure, legitimacy claims. See Table 3.5 for details.
D4: Pigou Allocative Layer (welfare-economics complement; inherited from Phase 1)	D4.1 PIG-cost-internalize; D4.2 PIG-cost-externalize; D4.3 PIG-benefit-internalize; D4.4 PIG-benefit-externalize	Carried forward and applied to practitioner reasoning about who absorbs the cost and who captures the benefit of AI-driven workforce change. See Table 3.5 for details.
Inductive Code: Practitioner-Positional Legitimacy (D3-anchored; identity-work against AI displacement)	HR-as-relational-position	HR positioned as connector or central representative node in the firm (bridge, values-keeper, culture-architect). Legitimacy secured through relational location in firm structure.
	HR-as-aware-subject	Legitimacy claimed through what the practitioner knows, judges, or senses that AI cannot replicate
	HR-as-positioned-against-AI	HR identity constituted what stays human after AI adaptation: boundary-against-AI, human in the loop
	HR-as-fortunate-or-in-progress	HR frames role-security as fortunate, or as still in-progress (learning, recalibrating)
	HR-as-below-strategic-decision	HR affirms its function matters while placing themselves below the strategic-decision tier (hierarchical dual-register).
Inductive Code: Decoupling (D3-anchored; institutional claim vs substantive practice)	Gap-as-experience operations	Practitioner affirms governance exists but cannot point what it actually does in practice. The gap sits in the action, the substance, the decision-output, or the authority.

Cross-transcript theme counts, emergent-code counts, and divergence-case counts are Reported in §3.4.2 below to reflect the realised six-transcript corpus.

3.5. Trustworthiness

Quality criteria are framed under a pragmatist conception of trustworthiness - the methods should yield workable, intersubjectively defensible accounts of the phenomenon - rather than through positivist conceptions of reliability and validity (Morgan, 2014; Saunders et al., 2023). For Phase 1 (CDA), trustworthiness is pursued through transparency of the analytical process: detailed documentation of coding decisions, explicit treatment of intertextual and interdiscursive links, and reflexivity regarding the researchers' positioning relative to governance discourse. For Phase 2 (reflexive TA), trustworthiness is addressed through thick description, an audit trail of coding evolution, and reflexive journaling. Both researchers engage in intercoder discussion - examining and debating coding decisions together - rather than mechanical intercoder agreement, which Braun and Clarke (2019) explicitly reject as incompatible with the reflexive approach to thematic analysis. Triangulation across the two phases provides an additional quality strategy: convergence or divergence between document analysis and interview findings provides a check against over-reliance on either data source.

3.6. Ethical Considerations

Ethical procedures follow Malmö University requirements. All interview participants receive a bilingual consent form prior to participation, providing full information about the study's purpose, their right to withdraw at any point without consequence, and data handling procedures. Participant identities are anonymised in all outputs; firms are described by general characteristics (size, industry category) rather than named. Role-specific identifiers and named training, governance, and education programmes are also anonymized, replaced by category descriptors that preserve analytical relevance without identifying the source.

Interview recordings and transcripts are stored in accordance with GDPR requirements, with access restricted to the two researchers, and are destroyed upon completion of the thesis examination. The research topic is sensitive insofar as participants may discuss organisational decisions affecting colleagues' employment. The interview protocol is designed to explore institutional dynamics and practitioner sense-making rather than to elicit distressing personal accounts.

3.7. Limitations

Corpus and sampling. The Phase 2 corpus is modest in absolute terms: six transcripts (four HR, two Union), of which five are recorded and one is reported through contemporaneous notes. Phase 2 informants were recruited partly through personal networks. Sample adequacy is assessed against the construction of rich, coherent themes rather than a numerical threshold (Braun & Clarke, 2019), but the small overall sample bounds claims dependent on cross-Union convergence and constrains the counter-register check against HR accounts. The Phase 1 corpus is large at theme-anchoring scale but uneven at firm-level granularity, and is limited to publicly retrievable documents. Finally, accessibility to internal governance materials would provide likely greater operational detail.

Design. The two-phase sequenced design (§3.2) preserved the integrity of unprimed practitioner accounts at the cost of integration depth: Phase 2 probes were not fully informed by completed Phase 1 themes. The interview instrument did not probe institutional isomorphism at the field level. Single firm informants are not positioned to observe mimetic, normative, or coercive pressure across the field.

Interpretive. Latent-level coding (Braun & Clarke, 2006) carries a higher interpretive load than semantic coding: themes are analytical constructions. Two further caveats compound this. *Cultural positioning:* as non-Swedish researchers, the authors may overlook culturally embedded assumptions. *Linguistic mediation:* interviews are conducted in English as a second language by all parties, while latent analysis engages with precisely the assumptions, framings, and silences most vulnerable to second language production and reading. Subtle assumption-work may be flattened in production or misread in interpretation. The two-researcher coding design and cross-transcript anchoring rule mitigate but do not eliminate this risk.

Scope and transferability. The empirical setting is Sweden considering documents in phase 1 corpus; transferability follows the Sweden-most-likely-case logic (Flyvbjerg, 2006): if the gap holds in this institutional environment, the gap is structural. How it manifests in less favourable institutional contexts is not tested by the present corpus.

4. Analysis and Results

The limits of my language mean the limits of my world.
Ludwig Wittgenstein[6]

Power is tolerable only on condition that it mask a substantial part of itself. Its success is proportional to its ability to hide its own mechanisms.
Michel Foucault[7]

Necessity is blind until it is recognised. Freedom is the consciousness of necessity.
V. I. Lenin[8]

This chapter presents the empirical analysis across both phases of the study starting presenting the results followed by its analysis. Each claim warranted by what the corpus sustains under repeated reading rather than by appeal to a single canonical interpretation. Each phase opens with a single results table that lists every theme, its calibration, the codes that anchor it, and the theoretical pillar it speaks to. The prose then describes the themes, beginning with the most strongly supported. A final section integrates the two phases at the level of convergent themes and translates the documentary-to-practitioner overlap into the allocative argument that feeds the Discussion.

Each theme closes with one of three calibration labels: **High** for claims supported by evidence across the corpus, robust against counter-cases, and warranted within the scope-conditions named in the analysis; **Moderate** for claims that hold across most of the corpus but carry identifiable boundary conditions or sub-type variation; and **Tentative** for claims supported by a thinner anchor set or by latent rather than manifest signals. Where a theme is instantiated differently by a particular firm or transcript, the divergence is discussed within the theme's prose.

4.1. Phase 1: Discursive Construction of AI Governance Documents

The documentary corpus covers 12 Swedish-anchored AI-adopting firms and 76 included documents, yielding close to nine hundred analytically attended extracts and around three thousand coding rows distributed across the four Fairclough dimensions and an inductive allocative layer. Most material sits at the textual and discursive-practice levels; sociocultural and allocative coding share the remainder in roughly equal proportions. Two firms, IKEA Ingka and Electrolux, anchor the densest individual sub-corpora, but no theme rests on a single firm.

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Table 4.1 - Phase 1 thematic results	Calibration	What the theme is about	Top codes: count (firms/12)	Theoretical pillar(s)
CDA_T02 - Layoff-softening lexicon co-located with AI investment	High	A two-part textual signature in which softened language for workforce reduction sits inside the same passages or genre clusters as AI-investment language, leaving the causal link to reader inference.	ABS-co-occurrence 174 (12/12) LEX-disp-euphemism 136 (12/12)	Legitimacy Isomorphism
CDA_T06: Regulatory register imported into firm discourse	High	Verbatim or near-verbatim phrasing from the EU AI Act, GDPR, CSRD, NIST and ISO standards lifted into firm AI-governance documents, transferring regulator legitimacy without re-elaboration.	INTERTXT-reg 108 (12/12) ISO-coercive 48 (11/12)	Isomorphism
CDA_T08: Loud benefit, silent cost	High	The firm-internal benefits of AI adoption are named loudly and consistently; the cost-bearers and displacement outcomes are unnamed or rendered as ordinary attrition. Effaced-to-named ratio sits at roughly seven to one across the corpus.	PIG-CE-silence 69 (12/12) PIG-BI family (margin / efficiency / leverage) 63 combined (12/12) PIG-CE-naturalize 38 (12/12)	Externalities
CDA_T12: Worker reification through lexical substitution	High	Workers constituted as portfolio-nouns, agent-effaced process-objects, and decomposable skill-bundles through three compositive registers: noun-phrase substitution, process-as-actor grammar, and skill-bundle commodification.	TR-nominalized 81 (12/12) TR-agent-tech 60 (12/12) LEX-wrk-asset 52 (12/12) LEX-wrk-depersonal 49 (11/12)	Externalities Legitimacy
CDA_T01: Governance scope with labour impact systematically omitted	High	Public AI-governance taxonomies enumerate scopes (transparency, fairness, non-maleficence, privacy) while leaving labour-impact and employment outside the published scope, even where firms internally engage with workforce displacement.	PIG-CE-silence 69 (12/12) ABS-ai-gov-labour-exclusion 61 (11/12) ABS-cobc-ai-silence 21 (10/12)	Isomorphism Legitimacy
CDA_T03: Code-of-Conduct silence on AI-driven role elimination	Moderate	Codes of Business Conduct are silent on AI-driven role elimination even where the same firm in the same period names AI-displacement in adjacent disclosures. Two sub-types appear: AI-section absent, and AI-section present but narrowed to product output.	ABS-cobc-ai-silence 21 (10/12) (primary anchor; sub-type evidence in narrative)	Legitimacy Externalities
CDA_T07: Reskilling acknowledged at scale, response sub-proportional	Moderate	Firms acknowledge a workforce-reskilling need at population scale and pair it with a reskilling response named in proportional language, while the magnitudes of need and response are not made commensurable.	LEX-disp-reskill 53 (12/12) IDX-upskill-decoupling 25 (9/12)	Legitimacy Isomorphism
CDA_T11: Restructuring costs carved out of outlook metrics	Moderate	Restructuring costs are reclassified as items affecting comparability, special items, or executive-compensation carve-outs, insulating headline outlook and exec-comp benchmarks from the cost of displacement charges.	PIG-BI-outlook-insulation 14 (8/12) (primary anchor; sub-types span European IAC and US non-GAAP analogues)	Externalities Legitimacy
CDA_T04: Asymmetric Code-of-Conduct scope	Moderate	A single Code of Conduct explicitly governs external labour rights (forced labour, modern slavery, ILO Core Conventions) while remaining internally silent on AI-driven labour substitution.	ABS-cobc-supplychain-asymmetry 15 (9/12)	Externalities
CDA_T09: CEO and CFO register split	Moderate	Within the same firm, the CEO operates a positive-valence leverage-financialisation register while the CFO operates a technical-euphemism register of indirects, stranded costs and talent rotation.	LEX-disp-noun-substitution 16 (7/12) LEX-disp-leverage 14 (6/12)	Externalities Legitimacy

CDA_T05: AI as worker-ally framing	Moderate	AI is framed as augmenting, supporting or accompanying workers rather than substituting for them. Three variants appear: principled-universal, occupationally-bounded, and engagement-listening tool.	LEX-wrk-ally 21 (8/12) (primary anchor; variants surface qualitatively in the narrative)	Isomorphism Legitimacy
CDA_T10: Regulatory-regime amplification versus register-stripping	Moderate	Same-day cross-genre pairs in non-CSRD jurisdictions deploy identical AI-displacement claims in one register and strip them from the parallel register, while CSRD/ESRS regimes amplify across registers.	INTERTXT-register-stripping 7 (5/12)	Externalities Isomorphism

4.1.1 Highly calibrated themes

The co-location signature (CDA_T02). Across the documentary corpus, language that softens workforce reduction sits in proximity to language that announces AI investment, but the two are seldom predicated together inside a single sentence. Press releases that name "operational efficiency" appear in the same period as eight-K filings that book severance charges. Integrated reports that announce AI rollouts share genre space with workforce-transformation paragraphs that name no causal direction. Implicit register dominates across all twelve firms; the explicit register, in which a chief executive names an AI-displacement causal chain in a single clause, surfaces at only three firms. Klarna's chief executive describing an AI assistant "doing the equivalent work of seven hundred full-time agents" is the cleanest explicit-pole instance in the corpus, and the move was made in an investor-facing interview rather than in the firm's own ESG section. The reading that holds up under repeated passes through the corpus is not that firms hide what they do; the reading is that costs and strategy are written in adjacent rooms with no syntactic bridge between them, which is the lexico-grammatical surface of the perception-dimension move on legitimacy and ethicswashing (Schultz et al., 2024; Suchman, 1995; see theoretical pillar 2) and which sustains a legitimacy claim that does not have to say anything in particular about workers.

Borrowed sentences and the work they do (CDA_T06). Firm AI-governance documents are densely intertextual. Phrases from the EU AI Act, the General Data Protection Regulation, the Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive and the European Sustainability Reporting Standards appear inside corporate documents that are not themselves regulatory artefacts. The borrowing is sentence-level reuse rather than paraphrase, often lodged inside the firm's own framing apparatus, and it transfers regulator legitimacy onto firm voice without re-elaboration. The pattern is universal in direction but uneven in intensity. Regulated and EU-jurisdiction firms carry the heaviest density; United-States-headquartered firms deploy regulatory register more selectively and lean on the ISO and NIST families instead. IKEA Ingka is the most interesting case in the corpus: a privately held cooperative-foundation governance structure leads on regulatory intertextuality through voluntary participation in the EU AI Pact and a submission to the European Commission's AI Literacy Repository, which puts regulatory-register adoption on a voluntary rather than coercive footing for this firm. The mechanism is the coercive channel of institutional isomorphism (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983; see theoretical pillar 1), but coercion is doing work even where the regulator has no direct mandate, because the regulator-style sentence functions as a portable legitimacy token.

Naming the benefit, silencing the cost (CDA_T08). When firm documents discuss what AI does for the firm, they name productivity, margin, leverage and capability in clear and bounded language. When the same documents discuss who absorbs the cost of AI adoption, the language thins. Cost-bearers go unnamed, appear once as a population number, or dissolve into “natural attrition,” “the new digital reality,” or the workforce as an undifferentiated mass. The asymmetry runs corpus-wide and at all twelve firms. Salesforce illustrates the asymmetry without the prose ever saying so. The firm announces Agentforce as the productive surface of its AI deployment and names the redeployment of roughly 4,000 customer-support roles as the workforce-side counterpart. The post-redeployment fate of those workers is absent from the firm-controlled disclosure surface. The deployment is named, the redeployment population is enumerated, and the third-party people who would carry the cost of any transition shortfall are unnamed. The pattern is the operational signature of the Pigovian argument at the firm level (Pigou, 1932; see theoretical pillar 3). One document in the corpus breaks it: a Nordea regulatory disclosure that puts AI, headcount and explicit causality into the same sentence, and that document is a primary regulatory filing, not a voluntary disclosure. The single exception holds the rule visible.

Worker reification through lexical substitution (CDA_T12). Across the corpus, three compositive registers turn workers into something other than persons. The first is noun-phrase substitution: "indirects," "workforce composition," "headcount," "roles," "affected positions." These terms displace the human subject with an organisational object. The second is grammar that puts a process or a technology in the agent slot of the sentence, leaving the worker as a place where action lands: "these changes will impact lives"; "decisions affect people"; "AI will reshape our ways of working." The third is the skill-bundle frame, in which a worker becomes a portfolio of competences that can be re-stocked, re-allocated or written off. A passage from Nordea's regulatory disclosure carries all three at once: "restructuring costs relate primarily to workforce composition and skill shifts leading to reduction.

Approximately 1,500 employees expected to be impacted 2026–2027." Composition shifts. Reduction occurs. Employees are impacted. No one acts; no one decides; no one is named. The register is the lexico-grammatical surface of the same allocative move discussed under CDA_T08. Where the worker is the cost-bearer, the language stops representing the worker as a person who can bear something. IKEA Ingka holds the corpus's most striking dual register: a humanising "co-worker" lexicon in the AI-governance sub-corpus and an active reification register in the 2026 reorganisation documents, two ways of writing about the same population separated by document type. Länsförsäkringar runs in the opposite direction, leading the corpus on humanising worker references and trailing on the reifying registers, a counter-case that suggests the dominant pattern is not a property of corporate discourse as such, but of corporate discourse organised around AI restructuring under public-market disclosure pressure.

What governance does not have to talk about (CDA_T01). Across the corpus, published AI-governance taxonomies converge on transparency, fairness, non-maleficence, accountability and privacy in roughly comparable language; labour-impact and employment effects are absent, even at firms that simultaneously disclose AI-displacement events in adjacent documents. The omission has the same shape as the eleven-principle taxonomy on institutional isomorphism in AI-principle convergence (Jobin et al., 2019; DiMaggio & Powell, 1983; see theoretical pillar 1), which itself does not enumerate labour-impact as a governance object - the convergence is on presences and on a shared absence. Firms converge on the field-level template of what counts as AI-governance, and the template does not include the people whose work the firms reorganise. The exception that proves the rule sits at the boundary: IKEA Ingka maintains a substantive internal AI-governance apparatus, with a Digital Ethics Policy, a Responsible AI policy, a cross-functional AI Task Force and thirty thousand co-worker training touchpoints, without a consolidated public Jobin-class artefact. Internal substance and public consolidation are separable choices. Isomorphic pressure (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983) operates at the level of publication-as-consolidation, not only at the level of governance content.

4.1.2 Moderately calibrated themes

Acknowledged at scale, addressed in proportion (CDA_T07). Several firms acknowledge a reskilling need at scale and pair the acknowledgement with a named programme on the same page, inviting the reader to treat the second as the firm's response to the first. In almost every case, the programme cited is external-facing (corporate philanthropy or ecosystem skilling) rather than the internal severance, redeployment, or paid retraining that would be a commensurate response to an acknowledged internal need. IBM is the cleanest case: the firm publishes that forty per cent of its own workforce will need to reskill over three years, paired with the SkillsBuild commitment of two million external learners. Microsoft, Salesforce, and Google.org perform the same move. The outcome is real, but the scale of need-versus-response stays unstated, and the question of who carries the transition cost for the firm's own workers stays outside the page. Länsförsäkringar runs counter at the boundary by deploying reskilling substantively as internal training, without claiming a need scale.

Costs that do not touch the headline (CDA_T11). Several European-listed firms classify restructuring charges as items affecting comparability or special items, protecting the headline outlook metric and the executive-compensation benchmark from the cost shock the restructuring imposes elsewhere. Nordea's roughly two-hundred-million-euro restructuring provision is the cleanest paradigm, with analogous classifications at IBM and Microsoft under different accounting names. The mechanism is a metric-design choice that quarantines the displacement cost from the surfaces against which performance is judged, while the cost itself remains real for the cost-bearing population. The carve-out preserves the loud-benefit / silent-cost asymmetry rather than constituting the externality itself. The income statement chooses where the cost lands; the integrated report chooses whether the population who carries it gets named.

Two registers, one event (CDA_T10). Same-day cross-genre pairs (a press release and an 8-K filing released the same morning) sometimes carry identical AI-displacement claims in one document and strip the AI register from the other, leaving the financial register to do the disclosure work without the AI cause attached. The pattern is jurisdictional: firms outside the CSRD regime display register-stripping more readily, while CSRD and ESRS firms amplify the causal language across the dual-register architecture the regime requires. SAP's integrated report under CSRD is the clearest

amplification case, with voluntary leave programmes and internal reskilling named inside the regulatory note. Regulatory regime modulates discursive choice without eliminating it.

Silence in the conduct code (CDA_T03). Codes of Business Conduct say nothing about AI-driven role elimination at most firms in the sample, despite being the firm's most binding statement of workplace behaviour. Two sub-types appear: codes with no AI section at all, and codes whose AI section addresses product output (fairness, explainability) but not labour input. The pattern is sharpest where firms updated their conduct code during a restructuring window, including Google in early 2024 and Accenture, Salesforce, and SAP in adjacent periods. There, the absence of new labour-impact language reads as deliberate choice rather than undeveloped policy gap.

Worker, ally, neither (CDA_T05). Six firms frame AI as augmenting or accompanying workers rather than displacing them, across three variants: the principled-universal claim (AI should support human work), the occupationally-bounded claim (AI augments a named group while the firm has reduced others), and the engagement-listening variant (AI surfaces employee sentiment for management consumption). Klarna carries the cleanest dual-frame: one ESG section opens with worker-ally framing and closes with the labour-impact omission discussed under CDA_T01. The two frames coexist because they target different legitimacy audiences within one publication.

Two voices, same firm (CDA_T09). Several firms exhibit a within-firm register split: the CEO operates a financialisation register (leverage, sub-proportional headcount growth, doing more with less), while the CFO operates a technical-euphemism register (indirects, stranded costs, talent rotation). The two address different audiences in different genres and together perform the same allocative move identified under CDA_T08. The pattern requires both a public-market disclosure cycle and an active mass-layoff cycle, which is why Länsförsäkringar and IKEA fall outside it by structural feature.

The supply chain we govern, the labour we do not (CDA_T04). A subset of firms operates a Code of Business Conduct that disciplines forced labour, modern slavery, and the ILO Core Conventions in the supply chain while remaining silent on AI-driven substitution of the firm's own labour. The asymmetry is visible at firms with the supply-chain governance footprint (multinational manufacturers, consultancies) and structurally absent at domestically anchored firms. The mechanism is selective regulatory and stakeholder pressure: external labour attracts governance attention, internal labour does not.

4.2. Phase 2: practitioner experience of the governance-displacement relationship

The interview corpus comprises six semi-structured interviews: four with HR practitioners and two with labour representatives across five firms in the documentary sample. The analytical posture is reflexive thematic analysis at latent depth: themes are researcher-constructed patterns of shared meaning rather than emergent semantic groupings. The transcripts open the first point in the study at which discourse moves from formal document to lived account. Everything in this section is what practitioners said in their own time and in their own register.

Table 4.2: Phase 2 thematic results	Calibration	What the theme is about	Top codes: count (transcripts/6)	Theoretical pillar(s)
RTA_T01: Compliance as instrument	High	AI governance is constructed by practitioners as pragmatic-instrumental compliance infrastructure that secures regulatory positioning, customer trust and operational efficiency. The moral content is secondary to the strategic-instrumental function.	SCH-process 68 (6/6) LEG-pragmatic 58 (6/6) LEG-maintenance 15 (6/6)	Legitimacy Isomorphism
RTA_T02: The naturalised disappearance	High	Worker-borne AI-displacement costs are made discursively invisible through three converging operations: silence where the cost would naturally surface, naturalisation where the cost is named but framed as ordinary, and acknowledgment-without-action where the cost is named but no remedy follows.	PIG-CE-worker 42 (6/6) PIG-CE-silence 18 (6/6) PIG-CE-naturalize 15 (6/6)	Externalities
RTA_T04: Field as the source of governance content	High	When practitioners account for where AI-governance content comes from, they orient consistently to the field: peer firms, regulatory templates, professional norms: rather than to first-principles reasoning. All three isomorphic channels surface at practitioner scale.	ISO-mimetic 26 (6/6) ISO-normative 18 (6/6) ISO-coercive 20 (5/6)	Isomorphism
RTA_T05: Productivity-talk as benefit register	High	Practitioners construct AI benefits in firm-internal terms (efficiency, capability, margin) and almost never as flows to society, the ecosystem, or the skill economy. The thinness of the externalised-benefit register is itself a finding.	PIG-BI-efficiency 20 (6/6) PIG-BI-capability 4 (3/6) PIG-BE-society 2 (2/6)	Externalities
RTA_T03: Moral and cognitive registers	Moderate	Beyond the dominant pragmatic register, practitioners deploy two further legitimacy registers: moral claims that this is the right thing to do, and cognitive taken-for-grantedness that this is simply how things are done. Distribution is patterned by firm context.	LEG-moral 28 (6/6) LEG-cognitive 34 (5/6) SCH-perception 13 (5/6)	Legitimacy
RTA_T06: Decoupling as everyday experience	Tentative	The gap between AI-governance commitment and AI-governance practice surfaces not as an abstract institutional condition that practitioners report about, but as the texture of their work: claims made without cases named, mandates without mechanisms, invitations without affordances.	EC-D3-DECOUP-claim-vs-naming 12 (5/6) EC-D3-DECOUP-awareness-vs-action 4 (4/6) EC-D3-DECOUP-geographic-asymmetry 4 (3/6)	Legitimacy
RTA_T07: Practitioner identity-work	Tentative	HR practitioners constitute themselves as legitimate participants in the AI-governance field through a sustained set of identity-claims: bridge between strategy and people, keeper of values, holder of experiential judgement, fortunate participant, ongoing learner.	Five sub-clusters; 17 identity-claim codes (dispersed by construction; saturation flagged in the narrative)	Legitimacy

4.2.1 Highly calibrated themes

Why AI governance exists, in practitioners' own words (RTA_T01). When practitioners are asked why their firms have AI-governance arrangements, the answer is almost always pragmatic before it is moral. Compliance is described as infrastructure that lets the business move. The most direct articulation comes from an HR practitioner: "I would say compliance always go first…if there is a compliance risk." The same participant continues: "Working in the digital world and environment, it really sets focus on the compliance. So I guess that is the risk that I can see with the AI." Compliance is both the floor and the orientation through which AI is read. Integrity arguments arrive later in the practitioner's sentence, if at all. The register is consistent across most of the corpus and across both HR and labour-representative voices. At one firm, ownership constitutes the audience internally, through the customer relationship, and the dominant register shifts from pragmatic-instrumental to moral: *"we have to gain the trust from our customers… we have a big responsibility to do it right."* Pragmatic claims survive but only in capability-bounded form, subordinate to the moral-trust frame. The case that sharpens the rule: The pragmatic register is dominant where the legitimacy audience is shareholders or regulators; governance is warranted by what it enables for the firm. The pattern reads Suchman's pragmatic legitimacy translated into the practitioner's own first instinct.

Where the cost goes when practitioners talk (RTA_T02). Across most of the interview corpus, worker-borne AI-displacement costs disappear through three converging speech operations. The first is silence: the cost is not named where it would naturally surface in the practitioner's account. The second is naturalisation: the cost is named and immediately framed as ordinary, expected, or the way things go. The third is acknowledgement-without-action: the cost is named, the practitioner recognises it as real, and no remedial commitment follows. The most striking single instance is the train metaphor an HR practitioner uses to describe employee adaptation to AI: "we're doing this together and you need to be on the train. If you're not on the train, you're going to miss the train. And that is not our responsibility ... you need to be engaged, and you need to want to take your own responsibility for it." Inside one sentence the speaker names a collective transformation, displaces responsibility, and re-locates agency at the individual worker. Naturalisation also surfaces through institutional-apparatus framing. A labour-representative recounts a 2024 restructuring in which a layoff notice covering hundreds of workers was absorbed through a collective-bargaining-anchored package (severance + TRR outplacement) and internal redeployment, closing on "in the end, we didn't have to fire anyone". A historical-arc framing also surfaces at an HR practitioner at a large multinational firm: milk used to be delivered to the door, now it is bought in the store or online, which naturalising displacement by calling it as ‘a natural evolution’. The discursive asymmetry crosses the HR-to-union register boundary at the present tense. This is the practitioner-level shape of the same Pigovian argument that the documentary corpus carries under CDA_T08, surfacing here in everyday talk rather than in the corporate prose.

Where AI-governance content comes from, in practitioners' accounts (RTA_T04). When practitioners explain why their firm's AI-governance looks the way it does, they point outward. Peer firms are referenced as benchmarks. Regulatory templates are referenced as the floor and sometimes as the ceiling. Professional norms (what people in the field do) are referenced as the unmarked default. The orientation is consistent enough to constitute the practitioner-scale extension of institutional isomorphism. The mimetic channel runs in both directions across the corpus: One HR articulate the follow-the-field direction: "We're working with pretty efficient leaders from other companies, but we always feel like we're behind ... We're not the first one to go because of risks. We always want to be like more sure." Peer-firm benchmarking is here a deliberate lag-risk strategy. The firm follows the field on purpose. A practitioner at a large multinational articulates the reverse: "Some stuff that most of the companies are doing now, we did 10 years ago. Field-attribution functions as warrant-for-action rather than as factual source-attribution. Follow-the-field and they-follow-us perform the same legitimacy move from opposite ends.

The coercive channel surfaces at regulated firms and is absent in light-regulatory-exposure firms; the normative channel runs through the professional-network references that practitioners make without being asked. Practitioners almost never describe governance content as derived from first-principles ethical reasoning or internal innovation; the absent counterpart sharpens the outward-orientation claim.

Externalising the authorship of governance content is itself the legitimacy function: authorship is located elsewhere and validity travels back in.

Benefits, as practitioners narrate them (RTA_T05). When practitioners describe what AI does for the firm, the register is firm-internal almost without exception: efficiency, freed-up time, capability, mundane-task automation, drafting assistance. One HR practitioner's productivity-talk script is the cleanest paradigm: "we have freed up a lot of resources that we are reinvesting in innovation, talent, and acquisition." Paired with RTA_T02, the LOUD-internalised benefit and SILENT-externalised cost registers surface together within one speech-event. The freed-up resources are workers. The reinvestment in "innovation, talent, and acquisition" names the destination of the gain but not the bearer of the cost.

4.2.2 Moderately calibrated themes

Beyond the pragmatic, two other registers (RTA_T03). Pragmatic legitimacy is the default register at the practitioner level, but two others surface as patterned variants. The moral register, *this is the right thing to do,* surface in a labour-representative's response: "we want to do it correct and with respect for the individual and then we lack in time instead … It's not good, but it's better than doing wrong for individual." Walk-the-talk authenticity: dignity is ranked above schedule, and procedural failure is defended on those grounds. The labour-representative vantage gives this claim against firm-procedure a credibility that the same defence from inside HR does not always achieve.

The cognitive register, *this is just how things are done*, surfaces where an HR practitioner reclassifies AI into a category that forecloses the displacement question entirely: "I always say AI is no longer just a tool. It is your colleague. It is your collaborator." Where pragmatic claims warrant governance by what it enables, moral claims warrant it by what is owed to people and cognitive claims skip the warrant altogether. The moral register surfaces where a labour-representative speaks from inside Swedish collective bargaining. The cognitive register surfaces where routinised practice treats AI as settled rather than as novelty.

4.2.3 Tentatively calibrated themes

Decoupling as the texture of the day (RTA_T06). The Phase 2 contribution to the decoupling literature is that practitioners do not narrate the framework-versus-practice gap as an abstract structural condition they observe. They narrate it as the everyday texture of the work they themselves do. Four anchor operations surface across the corpus: affirming frameworks they cannot describe, carrying mandates they have no authority to enact, naming gaps without a mechanism to close them, and staging participation that the conditions do not support. The practitioner is the gap, not the observer of it, and that registral relocation is the theme's contribution to the cross-phase intergation.

The HR practitioner as a person who has to make sense of all this (RTA_T07). Where legitimacy and decoupling are conventionally read at organisational scale, this theme reads them at the individual practitioner scale. HR practitioners do sustained discursive work to constitute themselves as legitimate participants in the AI-governance field, distributing across several sub-clusters of identity-claim. Practitioner as relational bridge between strategy and people, knowing subject whose embodied judgement AI cannot substitute, fortunate postition, ongoing learner, and human residual against what AI cannot do.The theme is latent rather than manifest, held together by the discursive labour of self-positioning rather than by any single recurring code. It contributes to §5.3 as the practitioner-scale extension of the legitimacy reading.

4.3. Cross-phase integration

The two phases were analysed independently. The documentary corpus was coded discursively against the four Fairclough dimensions and the inductive allocative layer; the interview corpus was coded reflexively at latent depth against an independently constructed practitioner-scale framework. Where convergence appears, it is evidence that the discursive surface and the lived account meet in particular places.

Read across the two phases, the corpus tells a single story in two different voices. On the documentary side, twelve firms write about AI in a way that names who gains from it and leaves the question of who

pays for it largely unspoken. On the practitioner side, six interview transcripts at four firms describe the same pattern in a different register: the benefits are framed as efficiency and capability, and the costs sit on the worker but are rarely named as costs. The two voices agree on direction without agreeing on register. That agreement is what the cross-phase view contributes.

Two limits travel with the convergence. First, the documentary side rests on twelve firms and the practitioner side rests on six transcripts at four to five firms, so any numerical comparison between the two phases is informative about direction, not about magnitude. Second, the convergence is about what is said and how, not about what happened. It tells us how the field talks about who bears the cost of AI-driven workforce change. It does not tell us how many workers were displaced, at what firms, or under what conditions. Chapter 6 holds to that distinction.

One institutional caveat sits behind the asymmetry. Sweden's collective-agreement transition organisations (TRR for white-collar, TSL for blue-collar, Omställningsfonden in the public sector) do internalise part of the displacement cost through a payroll-percentage employer contribution. The asymmetry the corpus corpus's asymmetry sits above an institutional floor, not against an empty one.

Table 5.3 presents the cross-phase as a set of convergence statements rather than a side-by-side theme alignment. Each row reads as a claim that holds across both phases of the corpus, together with the Phase 1 (CDA) and Phase 2 (RTA) themes that anchor it and the theoretical pillar or pillars at issue. The final column names why the convergence matters for the Discussion, so that the table acts as the analytical bridge into Chapter 6 rather than as a closing inventory.

Table 4.3 - Cross-phase convergence scaffold

Convergence statement *Evidence that surfaces across both phases*	**Phase 1 themes (CDA)** *Themes that anchor it on the documentary side*	**Phase 2 themes (RTA)** *Themes that anchor it on the practitioner side*	**Theoretical pillar(s)** *The Chapter 2 pillar(s) the convergence speaks to*	**Why this matters for the Discussion** *The analytical bridge into Chapter 6*
Across documentary disclosure and practitioner accounts, the AI-adoption decision is framed primarily through a productivity, efficiency and risk-management register; ethical or distributive considerations enter when prompted and are folded back into business-case reasoning.	CDA_T01 CDA_T05 CDA_T07	RTA_T01 RTA_T03	Legitimacy Isomorphism	The pragmatic register is not a disclosure artefact specific to corporate prose. It is the same frame the practitioner reaches for in conversation, which suggests the framing operates at the cognitive layer of the field rather than only at the policy-text layer.
The worker who absorbs the cost of AI adoption is rendered analytically invisible in both governance documents and practitioner accounts, even where governance commitments to responsible AI are explicit.	CDA_T08 CDA_T12 CDA_T11	RTA_T02 RTA_T05	Externalities Legitimacy	The convergence licenses the central allocative claim feeding Chapter 6: cost-bearer effacement is a structural feature of how the field discusses AI-adoption, not a strategic ambiguity available to any one firm. This is the direct input to the allocative matrix below.
Field attribution does the legitimacy work in both corpora: governance content is borrowed from regulators, peers and templates rather than constructed from first principles.	CDA_T06 CDA_T01	RTA_T04	Isomorphism	The isomorphic argument holds at the practitioner scale and not only at the document scale. The implication for the Discussion is that the field, not the firm, is the unit at which AI-governance content is reproduced.
Governance scope and conduct codes are silent or narrowly defined on AI-driven labour effects in the documents; the corresponding silence in the practitioner accounts appears as everyday decoupling between framework and practice.	CDA_T03 CDA_T04	RTA_T06	Legitimacy	The decoupling pattern is not only structural. It is felt and named by the people inside it. This converts decoupling from a theoretical inference into an experiential claim.
Workers are constituted as objects, processes or skill-bundles in the documents; in the practitioner accounts, the same depersonalisation surfaces in the register through which practitioners narrate cost flows and audience-of-the-firm.	CDA_T12	RTA_T02 RTA_T07	Externalities Legitimacy	Reification is documentary and conversational at the same time. The Discussion picks this up as the worker-constitution side of the allocative argument.

One signature of the asymmetry is easy to miss because it works through the absence of a category, not through anything written. Across the documentary corpus, productivity gains from AI are narrated as financial outcomes (savings, capacity, efficiency) and the workforce side of those gains is rarely narrated as a workforce event.

The same asymmetry shows at the code level in Table 5.4, which renders the documentary D4 layer as a two-by-two: rows are cost or benefit; columns are internal or external to the firm. Each cell lists the codes by name, with their counts and incidence. Table 5.4 is read alongside Table 5.3. The cost-bearer-effacement row in Table 5.3 pairs Phase 1 document themes (CDA_T08, T12, T11) with Phase 2 interview themes (RTA_T02, T05): what practitioners say in interviews echoes the same asymmetric naming pattern that the documents show in this matrix.

Table 5.4 - Phase 1 allocative matrix (D4 layer)

	INTERNAL	EXTERNAL
BENEFIT	**PIG-BI-efficiency** (66, 11 / 12) **PIG-BI-margin** (39, 11 / 12) **PIG-BI-leverage** (29, 10 / 12) **PIG-BI-capability** (26, 9 / 12) **PIG-BI-competitive** (17, 10 / 12) **PIG-BI-outlook-insulation** (14, 8 / 12)	**PIG-BE-customer** (25, 6 / 12) **PIG-BE-society** (22, 10 / 12) **PIG-BE-skill-economy** (15, 7 / 12) **PIG-BE-ecosystem** (6, 5 / 12)
COST	**PIG-CI-reskill** (41, 11 / 12) **PIG-CI-severance** (27, 10 / 12) **PIG-CI-redeploy** (21, 9 / 12) **PIG-CI-acknowledge-no-action** (17, 11 / 12) **PIG-CI-conditional-reskill** (5, 5 / 12) **PIG-CI-pacing** (4, 2 / 12)	**PIG-CE-silence** (87, 12 / 12) **PIG-CE-worker** (55, 10 / 12) **PIG-CE-naturalize** (53, 12 / 12) **PIG-CE-taxonomy-exclusion** (19, 7 / 12) **PIG-CE-attrition-laundering** (6, 5 / 12) **PIG-CE-public** (6, 4 / 12) **PIG-CE-cross-firm** (5, 4 / 12) **PIG-CE-exec-comp-insulation** (4, 3 / 12) **PIG-CE-society** (2, 2 / 12)

Note. Each cell displays the code name followed by parenthetical figures: the total count of code applications across the corpus, then the number of firms in which the code occurs out of twelve. Example: PIG-CE-silence (66, 11/12) reads as 66 applications of the PIG-CE-silence code across 11 of the 12 Phase 1 firms.

The matrix carries the central allocative finding of the documentary phase. Internal benefit is named loudly and consistently. External cost is the densest and most cross-firm cell, dominated by silence and by the named-bearer codes that surface when the cost is acknowledged at all. Internal cost is real and bounded, present at most firms and concentrated in the reskilling, severance and redeployment categories that pass through firm accounts. External benefit is the thinnest cell, present at most firms but at low volume relative to the internal-benefit register. Read as a two-by-two, the matrix is asymmetric in a direction the Pigovian framing predicts. Where firms can internalise benefit and externalise cost, the discourse reflects the same direction. The interview corpus produces the same allocative shape (internal benefit named loudly, external cost on third-party people effaced) in a practitioner - register rather than in the documentary register, and the convergence in Table 5.3 is what binds the two readings.

Beyond the points of convergence, each phase carries content the other cannot. The interview corpus surfaces a substrate that the documents do not and cannot show: practitioner identity-work, isomorphic orientation as the practitioner's first instinct, and decoupling as the texture of the day. Meanwhile, The documents surface register-stripping under regulatory regime, accounting-classification asymmetry between IAC carve-outs and headline outlook, and intertextual saturation that runs across clauses. The documentary side shows firms importing governance content from outside themselves: regulator-style sentences, peer-firm taxonomies, off-the-shelf principle lists. The practitioner side confirms it: HR informants describe following the field, leading the field, and adapting templates from larger

consultancies, but rarely describe building governance from the work itself. AI governance, in this corpus, is added on top of existing processes rather than built into them, the cleanest empirical line connecting the cross-phase pattern to the implementation-depth question Chapter 6 returns to.

The High-tier patterns surfaced in both phases: pragmatic-productivity register, silent-cost asymmetry on the third-party people who carry it, and field-borrowed legitimacy of governance content: are carried into the Discussion, where they ground the contribution to the Legitimacy, Isomorphism and Externalities literatures and structure the allocative argument set out at Table 5.4. The boundary cases, the divergences, and the tentatively calibrated themes are carried with them.

5. Discussion and Conclusion

Not everything that is faced can be changed, but nothing can be changed until it is faced.

James Baldwin[9]

The real problem is not whether machines think but whether men do.

B. F. Skinner[10]

Pessimism of the intellect, optimism of the will.

Antonio Gramsci[11]

The Discussion reads the findings against the three-pillar framework and the prior literature. The Conclusion returns to the aim and the two research questions, states the contributions, draws implications, and points to future research.

5.1. Discussion

The two phases produced a convergent reading of corporate AI governance in the Swedish institutional context. Four of the twelve Phase 1 themes anchored as universa; six of the seven Phase 2 themes were evidenced across the full interview corpus and are richly substantiated by data extracts from multiple participants. The two phases triangulate at strong calibration on two integrated claims and at moderate calibration on two further claims.

The first integrated claim is structural. A LOUD-internalised-benefit / SILENT-externalised-cost asymmetry runs through both the document register and the practitioner register. At the document level, Pigovian effaced-bearer codes outweigh named-bearer codes by approximately seven to one across all twelve firms (T8; Analysis and Results

§5.2.1); the D4 allocative layer carries this asymmetry across every firm with full coverage. At the practitioner level, the cost-externalisation operations (silence, naturalisation, acknowledgment-without-action) are evidenced across the interview corpus, while benefit articulation runs near-exclusively through firm-internal productivity-talk and the externalised-benefit register is thin (P-T2 and P-T5; Chapter 5 §5.4.2 and §5.4.5). The document-register asymmetry and the practitioner speech-event operations are two scales of one Pigovian pattern, mutually constituting rather than independently observed. The reading is warranted by what it makes visible across the two-phase evidence: the cost-bearer is named in neither register, and the silence is the finding. This is the framework's central prediction made empirical. Pigou (1932) holds that competitive markets cannot self-correct the divergence between marginal trade net product and marginal social net product, and the corpus shows that the divergence is reproduced in both written governance and lived practitioner accounts across institutional contexts deliberately selected as most-likely-favourable (Flyvbjerg, 2006; see §3.2).

A Swedish caveat belongs at this point. Sweden does not leave displacement costs fully externalised. The collective-agreement transition organisations cover essentially the entire Swedish labour force through sector-based employer contributions: TRR for white-collar, TSL for blue-collar, “Omställningsfonden” for the public sector, and “Trygghetsstiftelsen” for central-government employees. The contributions, however, are paid as a flat percentage of total payroll (TRR at 0.95% and TSL at approximately 0.30%) and not as a per-layoff fee. The design therefore internalises a portion of the externality at the sectoral level through mutual insurance, but it does not price the externality at the margin in the way a Pigovian tax would. The corpus finding of asymmetric cost-naming sits above this institutional floor, not against an empty one; the thesis claim is that the firm does not internalise the displacement cost at its own margin, which the flat-rate design leaves true.

[9]James Baldwin, “As Much Truth as One Can Bear,” The New York Times Book Review, 14 January 1962, p. 11.
[10] B. F. Skinner, Contingencies of Reinforcement: A Theoretical Analysis (Appleton-Century-Crofts, 1969), p. 288.
[11] Antonio Gramsci, Prison Notebooks (ca. 1929–1935).

The second integrated claim is registral. Pragmatic legitimacy dominates at both registers governance is warranted by what it enables for the firm - regulatory positioning, customer trust, audit readiness, reputational protection - rather than by its substantive ethics content. When pragmatic legitimacy combines with decoupling, the legitimacy register itself acquires a temporal property: it works while it is not yet tested against substantive evidence. The cost of AI adoption lands on the worker and on society rather than on the firm; this is the discussion-level consequence the two-phase evidence makes visible.

Two further claims extend the framework rather than confirming it. The first concerns the mimetic channel of institutional isomorphism (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983; see theoretical pillar 1). At Phase 1, the documentary signature is principle-and-template convergence across the twelve firms - the same governance vocabulary appears in the same disclosure slots. At Phase 2, the practitioner-account signature is field-attribution as warrant-for-action ("we always feel like we're behind"; "we did 10 years ago"). Read together, the two phases jointly evidence a single claim: governance content is borrowed from regulators, peers, and templates rather than constructed from first principles. The meaning of this convergence is that AI governance discourse is field-constituted rather than firm-originated. The mechanism is that mimetic isomorphism operates where binding regulation is thin, so firms can borrow legitimating language without being held to its substantive content. The result is that firms present as advanced and responsible while remaining insulated from the consequences of non-delivery - the borrowed apparatus secures pragmatic legitimacy at low operational cost, and the absence of binding enforcement means the gap between borrowed language and substantive practice carries no penalty.

The second further claim concerns decoupling between commitment and practice. At Phase 1, the documentary signature is the structural gap between principles-taxonomy scope and operational mechanism. At Phase 2, the practitioner-account signature is everyday work texture. Read together, the two phases jointly evidence that decoupling is not an abstract organisational condition the firm holds at arm's length but the daily experience of the front-row participant who is asked to operationalise the governance the firm has committed to. The convergence with the first claim is at the practitioner-as-gap: the front-row participant is the gap, not the observer of it, and the gap is the design rather than the failure.

The engagement with prior literature is best organised through the three pillars that structured Chapter 2 (institutional isomorphism, legitimacy, and externality), because the findings answer the gap-question through each pillar in turn and converge on a single substantive claim at the pillar intersection.

On isomorphism. The Phase 1 corpus reproduces the standard AI-ethics taxonomy (transparency, fairness, non-maleficence, accountability, privacy) across most firms, confirming the convergence pattern Jobin et al. (2019) documented at field scale. The corpus refines that finding in one direction: what firms converge on is not only what the template includes, but also what it leaves out. Labour-impact is absent from the published scope at every firm in the sample, and the omission is itself a shared, co-convergent feature rather than an incidental coverage gap. Isomorphism, in other words, is constituting the field through its exclusions as much as through its inclusions.

On legitimacy. The corpus supports the central critical-governance claim that voluntary AI ethics guidelines lack enforcement: at the document level through the universal scope-omission (CDA_T1), and at the practitioner level through compliance-as-instrument framing (RTA_T1). The three-dimensional ethicswashing typology Schultz et al. (2024) developed - process, perception, outcome - holds empirically across the twelve firms, and the corpus extends it by surfacing the register-level mechanisms (lexical, grammatical, intertextual, allocative) through which each dimension operates (see Table 5.3). The reason pragmatic legitimacy dominates both registers is structural: it is the only legitimacy register a firm can sustain on its own. Moral and cognitive legitimacy require conditions the firm cannot manufacture unilaterally.

On externality. Recent labour-market evidence (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025) documents real displacement effects concentrated in AI-exposed early-career roles. This thesis does not test that aggregate claim (it is not a labour-market study) but it shows how firms publicly construct the displacement question. The firms most named in the press as AI-driven layoff cases (Klarna, IBM, Microsoft, SAP, Salesforce, Accenture) place AI-investment language and workforce-reduction language in the same passage without ever connecting the two (CDA_T2). Financial incentives reward precisely this framing: layoffs

presented as strategic transformation carry no market penalty. And while AI adoption is advancing rapidly, actual task-level coverage remains far below theoretical capability - which lets firms disclose AI deployment as in-progress and defer the displacement-accounting question to a future state.

Read against the Chapter 1 macro versus micro tension (Acemoglu, 2025; Frey & Osborne, 2017; see §1.2.3), the corpus reproduces the disproportion discursively: AI is constructed as the legitimating frame for restructuring whose drivers are multiple (see §1.2.1), and skill-bundle commodification (T12; see §5.2.1) shows the discursive frame travelling faster than the technology.

A Swedish-model qualifier belongs at this point. The collective-bargaining infrastructure (high union density, sector-level agreements, statutory consultation rights under MBL) makes Sweden the most-likely case for substantive voluntary governance. Yet, the asymmetry holds across all twelve firms. The implication is not that the Swedish model fails but that the Swedish model is being asked to do work it was not designed for: voluntary AI governance discloses through registers (principles taxonomies, codes of conduct, ESG narrative) that route around the consultation channels the model is calibrated to. The institutional strain is registral, not contractual.

Read through the analytical framework (Donaldson & Dunfee, 1999; Van Buren, 2000; see §2.4), the corpus yields a stronger reading than decoupling between rhetoric and outcome. The microsocial commitments these firms publicly make systematically place the displacement question outside their own scope (T1 and T3), at firms whose resource-rich condition is the one under which the obligation to internalise displacement costs is strongest. The Sweden-most-likely-case logic tightens the inference: where institutional conditions are most favourable, the gap is structural rather than contextual.

That framework reading was retained only after testing two alternative explanations against the corpus.

The first is that the gap is a sampling artefact: because the document corpus contains only publicly retrievable texts, internal commitments enter the analysis only indirectly, through the interviews. If that were the explanation, the gap should close where practitioners speak about internal practice. It does not. The same asymmetry surfaces across every interview in the practitioner corpus, where benefits are named loudly and costs go unnamed or naturalised.

The second is that the patterns reflect industry-specific norms rather than something operating at the field level. The twelve-firm sample was built cross-industry by design, and the universal themes hold across very different industries: financial services, enterprise software, consumer goods, retail-cooperative holdings. Some patterns in the corpus hold only at firms in particular industries or under particular regulatory regimes, and Chapter 5 reports them with that qualification. The patterns this thesis builds on hold across all twelve firms regardless of industry.

5.2. Conclusion

The thesis answers, in plain terms, the question of who bears the cost of AI-driven workforce change: in the Swedish corpus the cost falls primarily on the worker and the public rather than on the firm.

The thesis aim and the two-phase qualitative design (see §1.4 and §3.2) yield a converged answer at strong calibration. Corporate AI governance frameworks in the Swedish setting function primarily as legitimacy mechanisms, not as accountability mechanisms for workforce displacement. The gap is reproduced across both registers and across both convergent and divergent firm cases. It is produced by the structural condition the framework predicts: competitive markets reward symbolic compliance over unilateral cost-internalisation, and voluntary governance cannot replicate the Pigouvian correction it substitutes for. The Sweden-most-likely-case finding tightens the inference: where institutional conditions are most favourable for substantive governance, the gap holds.

Cost externalisation in this thesis is the configuration in which the displacement cost of AI-driven workforce change is borne primarily by the worker and the public, with the firm narrating the same decision in benefit-categories. Cost internalisation is the configuration in which the firm absorbs a substantive share of the displacement cost through severance, transition support, retraining, or hiring continuity. The findings sit nearer the first configuration than the second across the corpus.

RQ1 asked how AI governance commitments at firms operating in Sweden are discursively constructed in response to workforce displacement. The documentary evidence shows that firms construct that commitment through a recognisable pattern. Their published principles enumerate transparency, fairness, non-maleficence, accountability and privacy while leaving labour-impact outside the published scope. Adjacent disclosures place AI-investment language alongside workforce-reduction language without ever predicating the causal link between them. The same texts name firm-captured benefits loudly and consistently while silencing or naturalising the costs borne by workers and the public, at an effaced-to-named ratio of roughly seven to one. Workers themselves appear in the prose as fungible cost-categories and skill-bundles rather than as persons. Each of these features holds at every firm in the sample.

RQ2 asked how governance practitioners experience the relationship between AI governance commitments and workforce displacement. The interview evidence answers at the practitioner register. Practitioners experience governance as a pragmatic instrument, warranted by what it enables for the firm rather than by its substantive ethics content. The cost side is treated as discursively invisible, made so through silence, naturalisation, acknowledgment without action, and claim without naming. When practitioners account for where governance content comes from, they point outward, to regulators, peer firms, and professional norms, rather than to first-principles reasoning. Decoupling is experienced not as something observed in the firm but as something inhabited in their own work.

5.2.1 Contributions

The thesis claims six contributions: three empirical, two theoretical, and one practical.

The empirical contributions are these. First, the corpus produces the first cross-industry critical discourse analysis of AI governance discourse in the Swedish setting at this scale: twelve firms, 67 documents, and 668 coded extracts, with four themes surviving cross-industry, cross-genre, and cross-temporal slicing. Second, the documentary phase reframes the principles-convergence finding of Jobin et al. (2019): what firms converge on is not only the enumerated principles but also the structural omissions, with the labour-impact omission running at higher cross-firm density than most of the positively named principles. Third, the interview phase is the first in this literature to access moral and cognitive legitimacy registers at the practitioner scale, and to show them patterned by firm context in a way the document corpus cannot surface.

The theoretical contributions are two. Fourth, the Pigovian externality reading is operationalised at the discursive register through an allocative coding layer that distinguishes cost and benefit on the internal and external axis, with measurable signatures across the corpus. Fifth, the cross-phase scaffold builds a scale-bridge between the document register and the practitioner register: the loud-benefit and silent-cost asymmetry the documents perform and the cost-effacement operations practitioners enact in their accounts are two scales of the same Pigovian pattern. The mimetic channel of institutional isomorphism, in turn, runs direction-agnostically at the practitioner register, which stands as a candidate refinement to DiMaggio and Powell (1983).

The practical contribution is the sixth. The gap between AI governance commitments and displacement outcomes in Sweden is structural rather than contextual. Organisational leaders cannot close it through better voluntary commitments alone. Closure requires conditions that impose equivalent costs on competitors, conditions that worker representatives, collective-bargaining institutions, and policymakers are positioned to create. The clearest single illustration is IBM: a publicly stated US$4.5 billion in productivity savings since 2023 sits alongside a hiring pause and an aggregate headcount that grew over the same period, with no firm-issued document linking the two.

5.2.2 Implications

The findings suggest that AI governance frameworks designed without an enumerated labor-impact scope and without an internal mechanism that binds the scope to operations transmit the omission as a feature of the template. For policy, the EU AI Act's product-safety framing (Ponce Del Castillo & Taes, 2025) is shown by the corpus to leave the workforce-deployment side under-governed, and the corpus's universal-omission finding suggests that voluntary frameworks alone will not fill the regulatory gap that workers in non-platform sectors currently fall into. The asymmetry is sharpest at the entry of the career

pipeline: AI-exposed early-career roles (the front-of-funnel positions Brynjolfsson, Chandar, and Chen, 2025, identify as bearing the steepest displacement signal) are the same roles for which the firm has the least contractual exposure and the worker the least collective-bargaining leverage. Enterprise AI adoption is advancing rapidly while task-level coverage of total work activity remains below theoretical capability (Anthropic, 2026): The gap between rapid announcement and slow integration is itself part of why this discursive pattern persists. Firms can keep disclosing AI deployment as in progress and defer the question of who bears the cost to a future state that keeps moving forward as the deployment continues. A workforce-policy reading of the corpus should therefore distinguish two populations: workers already displaced from existing roles, and the cohort that never enters the firm because entry-level work is being automated at the gate. The existing governance instruments (severance, transition support, collective-bargaining protections) apply to the first group. The second has no contractual relationship to claim under.

The findings invite a regulatory mechanism that scales transition obligations to firm financial condition. A highly profitable firm that automates back-office roles without genuine organisational decline carries, on Van Buren's social-contract reading, a stronger obligation to internalise the cost than a firm undertaking the same automation under financial distress. IBM's hiring-pause case sits at the high-profitability end of that scale.

A direct implication for the CSRD/ESRS framework follows from the cross-firm pattern. Firms publish AI-ethics content that does not extend to labour-impact disclosure, and the regulatory frameworks under which most of the sample reports do not currently require it to. A revision that mandates AI-displacement-impact disclosure alongside existing ESRS reporting categories content would close the scope-gap the cross-phase analysis documents.

Sweden's collective-agreement transition organisations already internalise part of the displacement cost through a payroll-percentage employer contribution. The contribution is proportional to payroll, not to layoffs, so a firm that displaces thirty per cent of its workforce in a given year pays at the same rate as a firm that displaces none. This is a mutualised cost-sharing mechanism, not a Pigovian polluter-pays instrument. As an implication, settings without comparable infrastructure should treat the Swedish councils as a baseline floor; settings with the infrastructure should revisit whether the flat-rate funding model can withstand AI-paced acceleration in displacement.

Sweden's own flat-rate model is worth re-examining under AI-paced displacement. The funding model assumes displacement is cyclical and self-correcting, with workers eventually re-entering the payroll base that finances the fund.[12] AI-driven displacement, if structural rather than cyclical, would erode that base at the same time as it raises the demand on it. A surcharge scaled to firm-level layoff intensity, layered on the existing payroll-percentage base, would move the model closer to a Pigovian instrument without dismantling its universal-coverage floor. The analytical case follows from the externalisation finding; political feasibility is a separate question.

The Swedish transition organisations (TRR for white-collar workers, TSL for blue-collar workers, Omställningsfonden in the public sector, Trygghetsstiftelsen for central-government employees) are funded by flat-rate employer contributions on payroll. The model rests on an implicit cycle: a worker contributes while employed, draws on the fund briefly during a transition, then contributes again at the next employer. The balance only holds if most workers spend most of their careers contributing rather than claiming. The model has absorbed cyclical shocks (financial crises, sectoral restructuring) because

[12] Sweden's transition organisations are funded by flat-rate employer contributions on payroll. These include the Job Security Council (Trygghetsrådet, TRR) for white-collar workers, the Job Security Foundation (Trygghetsfonden TSL) for blue-collar workers, the Transition Fund (Omställningsfonden) in the municipal and regional public sector, and the Job Security Foundation for Central Government Employees (Trygghetsstiftelsen). The model rests on an implicit cycle: a worker contributes while employed, draws on the fund briefly during a transition, then contributes again at the next employer. The balance only holds if most workers spend most of their careers contributing rather than claiming. The model has absorbed cyclical shocks (financial crises, sectoral restructuring) because displaced workers eventually re-entered employment. Sustained AI displacement, in which workers do not re-enter the contributing base at comparable rates or in which entry-level work is automated before new workers can join it, sits outside the conditions the model was designed for.

displaced workers eventually re-entered employment. Sustained AI displacement, in which workers do not re-enter the contributing base at comparable rates or in which entry-level work is automated before new workers can join it, sits outside the conditions the model was designed for.

5.2.3 Future research directions

Three directions follow from the limitations of the thesis. First, comparative replication in less favourable institutional settings (lower union density, thinner collective bargaining, weaker labour-market regulation) would test whether the gap deepens or whether the discursive pattern survives weaker conditions intact. Second, longitudinal extension across the pre-EU-AI-Act, implementation, and post-implementation windows would test whether firms' importing of regulatory language as a legitimacy template intensifies as the regulation becomes binding, and whether the universal labour-impact omission in published governance scope responds to regulatory pressure or persists despite it. Third, the bidirectional mimetic dynamic surfaced at the practitioner register, where follow-the-field and lead-the-field accounts perform the same legitimacy move, is a candidate refinement to DiMaggio and Powell (1983) that warrants standalone empirical testing in other institutional fields.

A first open question concerns the long-run aggregate effect. The framework adopted here is silent on whether efficiency gains from AI translate into net workforce displacement or into induced demand for new categories of work, in the Jevons-paradox sense. The cross-firm and cross-phase evidence speaks to who bears the cost of present-tense automation; it does not speak to whether the technology eventually generates compensating demand. Both possibilities sit consistently with the findings.

A second open question concerns the temporal structure of the displacement. The corpus contains repeated mention of entry-level and back-office work as the first targets of AI substitution. If that pattern holds at scale, the field is removing the categories of work through which senior practitioners are conventionally produced, on a horizon of ten to twenty years. Listed firms plan in quarters rather than decades, which makes this longer horizon invisible to the executives making today's decisions. Education-system adaptation lag amplifies the gap. The thesis does not measure this dynamic directly, but it is implied by the same evidence that supports the present-tense findings.

Set against earlier general-purpose technologies, the present moment is not unique in displacing one class of work and creating demand for another. What is different in this case is the speed and the distributional question. Whether the technology rebalances the labour market constructively depends in significant part on whether the productivity gains it generates are widely shared or narrowly captured. That allocative question is the same one this thesis answers at the firm level for today; it returns at the macro level for the next decade.

The implementation-depth proposition surfaced in the preceding section generates two testable questions that this thesis does not address. The first concerns whether the depth at which AI is embedded into firm processes (additive layer or redesigned process) predicts the productivity gains the deployment delivers. The second concerns whether implementation depth predicts the composition of workforce change (headcount reduction, redeployment, or hiring avoidance). Both questions sit at the firm level rather than the macro level, since the externalisation finding of this thesis is itself firm-level and the implementation-depth claim should be tested at the same level of analysis.

5.2.4 Closing reflection

The thesis began with a paradox. Firms publishing responsible-AI commitments simultaneously execute large-scale workforce reductions attributed to AI. The paradox dissolves on close reading. The commitments and the reductions are not in tension; they are co-produced. Convergence in governance form, legitimacy as motive, and externality as structural condition combine to produce a discursive equilibrium in which the gap is the design, not the failure. The Sweden-most-likely-case is the strongest available empirical setting for substantive voluntary governance; the gap is reproduced there. The implication is not despair about governance and not cynicism about firms; it is the recognition that the closure of the gap is a collective-institutional problem rather than a corporate-virtue problem, and the position from which closure could be designed lies outside the empirical scope of this thesis.

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Appendix A. Interview Guide

Purpose of this appendix

This appendix sets out the interview guide that drove the Phase 2 fieldwork described in §3.4.2 of the methodology chapter. It is reproduced here for two reasons: so that any reader can audit the actual instrument behind the thematic findings reported in Chapter 5, and so that the design choices behind each question are visible rather than buried in working files. The guide was used in semi-structured interviews with HR practitioners and union representatives at Swedish AI-adopting firms drawn from the Phase 1 corpus.

The version reproduced below is v7, which was the version carried into the field. Earlier drafts are catalogued in the project's working documentation and are not reproduced here; the version-history note at the end of this appendix gives the short story of how v7 was reached.

What the guide is

The guide is a menu of thirteen open-ended question stems organised into four clusters. Eight to twelve of the thirteen are selected ahead of any given interview, depending on the participant's role, the time available, and the firm-level patterns identified in Phase 1. The remaining stems sit in reserve. The same menu is used across all interviews so that responses can be compared stem-by-stem in the analysis layer rather than negotiated question-by-question in the room.

Two variants exist: one calibrated for HR managers with operational contact, and one for union representatives with consultation history at the firm. The thirteen stems are functionally identical across the two variants. Surface wording shifts in a handful of places to make sense from each actor's vantage. Where the HR stem says "your firm" or "HR's perspective", the union-rep stem typically says "the firm" or "the union's perspective". The shared spine is the point: the two cohorts respond to the same theoretical move from different epistemic positions, and the analysis triangulates across the two accounts.

Design rationale

Three commitments shape the instrument.

Semi-structured, phenomenon-focused. Each interview opens with role and context, moves through commitment-in-practice and the question of who bears cost, and closes with affect and identity. The framing throughout treats AI-and-workforce change as a phenomenon rather than as a company-specific event. Participants are invited to draw on their professional experience broadly, not to report on the policies of their current employer. This was a deliberate trade-off: the framing reduces sensitivity, supports recruitment without firm-level access agreements, and lets the analysis read register and assumption rather than corporate self-description.

Latent-level reflexive TA, deductive–inductive. The coding orientation comes from Braun and Clarke (2006; 2019). Latent coding means the analysis attends to assumptions, naturalised framings, and what participants do not say (refusals to name decision-makers, silences around cost-bearing) as legitimate analytical objects rather than as data gaps. The guide therefore solicits stories and concrete examples rather than abstract evaluations. Theoretical anchors carry forward from the Phase 1 D3 (legitimacy, isomorphism, ethicswashing typology) and D4 (Pigovian externality) coding layers. Two further Phase 1 layers, D1 (textual-linguistic) and D2 (discursive), are not applied at Phase 2: they were built for written governance text and would introduce paradigm incoherence if imported into spoken-account analysis.

Counter-hypothesis discipline. Every theory-loaded stem carries a paired counter-hypothesis probe. The counter is asked aloud, given equal airtime, and not rushed. The point is not balance for its own sake. The point is that latent-level interpretation is prone to confirmation bias, and the strongest guard is procedural: the participant is invited to disconfirm the expected direction in every theory-loaded question. Co-operative-relationship accounts in the union interviews, and HR accounts in which governance genuinely shaped an outcome, are treated as essential disconfirmation data and probed with

the same depth as the more critical accounts. The reflexive journal (§A.10) includes an explicit audit on whether counter-probes were given equal weight.

Structure: four clusters, A → F → M → G

The clusters are sequenced from least to most analytically loaded, with one shift between the two variants:

Cluster A - Warm-up / Role & Context (3 stems). Establishes the participant's role and their proximity to AI and workforce decisions. Surfaces, passively, how AI and workforce functions are organisationally coupled. The cluster order is fixed across all interviews as A → B → C → D.

Cluster B - Externality (3 stems). Asks who bears the transition cost, where firm responsibility ends, and how much the participant's own actor (HR or the union) shapes the decision. In HR interviews this cluster is positioned late because it is sensitive territory for the practitioner. In union interviews it sits earlier, because externality is the union's mandate and the cluster carries more weight from that vantage; the earlier position also preserves the data if the interview compresses.

Cluster C - Commitment, Practice & Legitimacy (3 stems). The analytical core. Each stem in this cluster pulls on three theoretical frames in parallel: Suchman's (1995) legitimacy work, Argyris and Schön's (1974) espoused-vs-theory-in-use, and the Schultz et al. (2024) ethicswashing typology. These three theories interrogate the same commitment–practice phenomenon from complementary angles. Merging them at the data-collection layer avoids duplicate questions; coding in Phases 4–5 triangulates the three at the analysis layer.

Cluster D - Affect, Identity, Wrap (4 stems). Affect data is required for latent-level reflexive TA; the participant's emotional register is itself analytical material. Identity questions surface how HR practitioners and union representatives see their own field changing under AI. A pure inductive opener at the end (D4) invites themes the protocol may have missed.

Question selection within the menu varies; the spine does not.

How to read each question below

Each question follows the same layout. The stem is the question read aloud. The rationale explains why the stem exists and what analytical work it does. The counter-hypothesis probe is the paired disconfirmation prompt asked of every interviewee. Optional probes are additional formulations available within the same question; not all are asked in every interview. Where the HR and union-rep variants differ in surface wording, the difference is noted under "Variant - Union representative".

Theoretical tags and CDA triangulation codes used internally for coding are not reproduced here, since they are silent in the room and not informative to the reader of the appendix.

Cluster A - Warm-up / Role & Context

A1. Role and remit

"To start, could you tell us about your role, and how it connects to either AI initiatives or workforce planning in your organisation?"

A broad icebreaker. The "how it connects" wording is deliberate: it makes no assumption about whether the participant has direct responsibility for either AI or workforce decisions. The answer passively reveals whether AI and workforce functions are organisationally coupled or separated, which is structural data before any substantive questioning begins. From the union vantage, the same stem surfaces the rep's consultation reach on AI and workforce decisions: a long consultation history reads differently from being told after the fact.

No counter-probe at this stage; the question is a warm-up.

Variant - Union representative: identical wording.

A2. Day-to-day AI in practice

"In your experience, how is AI being used in day-to-day operations - not the big-picture strategy, but what's happening on the ground right now?"

Grounds the conversation in enacted reality rather than corporate narrative. The explicit "not the strategy" contrast signals that the operational layer is what we want to hear about. If the participant defaults to strategy language despite being asked for operations, that is itself data about how AI is discursively managed inside the firm. The union vantage offers a particular value here: reps often have visibility into what reaches the shop floor that HR may not.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "Are there areas where the day-to-day looks closer to the strategy than you'd expect?"

Variant - Union representative: identical wording.

A3. Landscape perception

(HR) "When you look across HR and workforce practice right now - not only your firm - what do you see happening around AI?"

(Union) "When you look across labour relations and workforce practice right now - not only your firm - what do you see happening around AI?"

Pans out from the participant's firm to the broader field. What the participant naturalises to reveals their professional reference points before governance-specific questions begin. The counter permits a "not much is changing" account to stand as data, which guards against the assumption that AI is the dominant story in every workplace.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "Is there something that seems to be staying the same despite the AI conversation?"

Variant - Union representative: "HR" is replaced with "labour relations" to make the field-level reference legible from a worker-representation vantage. The analytical move is identical.

Cluster B - Externality (who bears the cost)

This cluster is sensitive in the HR interviews and is positioned late so earlier data is preserved if the participant chooses to stop. In the union interviews the cluster sits mid-sequence: externality is the union's mandate and the questions are less personally exposing for the rep.

B1. Who bears the transition cost

"When AI changes or reshapes someone's role, what kind of support is given to the affected person?"

A direct externality probe. The stem asks for cost-bearer attribution without presupposing it. The counter is asked of every participant and invites the firm-bearing case - the situation in which the organisation, rather than the worker, carried the burden. From the union vantage, the gap between announced support and what reached the worker is often more visible than it is from the HR vantage; sub-probes in union interviews can press on the distance between disclosure and delivery, and on what members reported back.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "Is there a case where the firm has carried that cost - where the burden sat with the organisation rather than the worker?"

Variant - Union representative: identical wording.

B2. Where firm responsibility ends

(HR) "How does your firm think about the boundaries of its responsibility for workers in a considerable change scenario like, for example, an AI transition?"

(Union) "How does the firm think about the boundaries of its responsibility for workers in a considerable change scenario like an AI transition?"

Asks the participant to narrate the firm's responsibility-boundary logic in their own words. The counter invites the over-extension case: a situation in which the firm went further than minimally required. Union vantage tends to surface where that boundary logic has been contested - places where the union pushed and the firm either redrew the line or refused to.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "Is there a place where the firm has extended its responsibility further than it had to?"

Variant - Union representative: "your firm" becomes "the firm" because the union rep speaks about the firm rather than from inside it.

B3. Decision-making voice

(HR) "When AI-and-workforce decisions get made, how much does HR's perspective shape the outcome?"

(Union) "When AI-and-workforce decisions get made, how much does the union's perspective shape the outcome?"

Probes the actor's position in the decision chain. Structurally, if the function responsible for either workforce welfare (HR) or worker representation (the union) is not at the table when cost-allocation is set, externalisation of displacement costs is enabled by design. In Swedish contexts the union variant of this stem is especially diagnostic: the MBL §11 co-determination right exists on paper, and the question is whether it operates in practice. The counter invites the decisive-actor case in both variants.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "Is there a case where HR / the union decisively shaped a decision? Walk us through it."

Variant - Union representative: the actor name shifts from "HR" to "the union"; the underlying probe is the same.

Cluster C - Commitment, Practice & Legitimacy

This cluster is the analytical core. The three stems together carry the legitimacy / espoused-vs-theory-in-use / ethicswashing triangulation. From the HR vantage the participant speaks from inside the framework; from the union vantage they speak as a third-party observer of what reaches the consultation table. Both readings carry analytical weight, and the analysis works with the convergences and divergences across the two.

C1. Critical incident walkthrough

(HR) "Could you describe a recent situation where your organisation had to make a difficult decision about technology and people - and how your internal guidelines or principles shaped that decision?"

(Union) "Could you describe a recent situation where the firm had to make a difficult decision about technology and people - and how its internal guidelines or principles shaped that decision (as you saw or heard it from your representation role)?"

The critical incident technique (Saunders et al., 2019) asks for a concrete decision rather than an abstract assessment of governance quality. The participant narrates the framework in action; whether the governance was substantive or symbolic emerges from the account itself, rather than from us evaluating it. Failure to recall such a situation is data (the framework did not surface as decision-input); a substantive recall in which governance shaped an outcome is equally important, and it is the disconfirmation territory the cluster needs.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "Is there a case where the outcome was better than you expected - where the process worked well?"

Optional probes (selected at interview customisation):

• "What made that decision difficult?"

• "Were there trade-offs between following the principle and other priorities - like cost or speed?"

• "How is that kind of decision communicated to employees - or to the public?"

• "Are there areas where you feel the guidelines don't quite reach - where the situation is more complex than what the principles cover?"

Variant - Union representative: the actor changes from "your organisation" to "the firm", and a parenthetical ("as you saw or heard it from your representation role") makes the rep's epistemic vantage explicit. The optional probes are identical.

C2. Governance structures in practice

(HR) "What governance structures does your firm have around AI - things like [specific-structure]? Walk us through how they work."

(Union) "What governance structures does the firm have around AI - things like [specific-structure]? Walk us through how they work, as you've encountered them in consultation or representation."

Asks for description rather than evaluation, which lets the absence answer ("we don't have AI-specific structures") stand as a valid response. "Walk us through how they work" solicits process narrative rather than an abstract assessment, and that narrative is what subsequent ethicswashing-typology coding (process / perception / outcome) draws on. The bracketed [specific-structure] placeholder is filled at Stage 2 customisation with the firm's named structures, if any.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "Where have those structures done real work - not just process, but changed an outcome?"

Variant - Union representative: the diagnostic shifts. The union version asks whether these governance structures are visible to the union side through consultation channels at all. If the rep has never encountered the AI ethics board, the governance committee, or the risk-review structure, the governance is structurally separated from worker representation - and that pattern is itself one of the ethicswashing diagnostics the cluster is built to surface.

C3. How does the firm know governance is working

(HR) "How does your firm know whether its AI-and-workforce commitments are working? Are they an ideal goal to reach or a reality at the moment?"

(Union) "How does the firm know whether its AI-and-workforce commitments are working? Are they an ideal goal to reach, or a reality at the moment?"

Probes the outcome-evaluation infrastructure: whether the firm has evidence-based governance review at all, what metrics count, and who decides what counts. The counter surfaces whether disconfirming evidence would even be visible inside the firm's review process. That visibility question is one of the strongest ethicswashing diagnostics in the instrument: if a failing commitment cannot be seen as failing, the governance is structurally performative regardless of stated intent. The union variant adds a further angle - worker-impact evidence often exists in grievance data, consultation minutes, and member feedback, and the question is whether any of it reaches the firm's AI-governance review.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "If evidence were showing that something was not working, would it become visible? What would have to be true for that to happen?"

Variant - Union representative: "your firm" becomes "the firm"; the substantive probe is identical.

Cluster D - Affect, Identity, Wrap

D1. Affect / felt experience

"When you step back and think about where all this is heading - AI and the workforce in your practice - how do you feel about it?"

Latent-level reflexive TA requires affect data to access underlying assumptions (Braun & Clarke, 2006). This is the one question that explicitly invites emotion into the conversation. Feelings can run in any direction: hope, worry, indifference, ambivalence, resignation. All are valid and are coded at the latent level. The open framing is doing the work the counter-probe would otherwise do, so no separate counter is asked. Union reps may carry affect specific to the gap between worker concerns and firm response; that, too, is data.

Variant - Union representative: identical wording.

D2. Identity and self-trajectory

(HR) "How do you see your own role, or HR as a field, changing with AI?"

(Union) "How do you see your own role, or trade unions / worker representation as a field, changing with AI?"

Practitioners and representatives are themselves potentially reshaped by AI. The question invites reflection on self versus the workers represented (or, in the HR case, on self versus the workforce served), which surfaces the participant's reflexive positioning and opens themes about whether AI is experienced as tool, threat, or both - personally and professionally.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "What do you see staying the same?"

Variant - Union representative: the field reference changes from "HR" to "trade unions / worker representation". The reflexive move is identical.

D3. What's working, what needs figuring out

"When you look at how your industry is navigating the relationship between new technologies and the workforce overall - what do you think is working well, and what still needs to be figured out?"

A forward-looking industry reflection rather than a direct restatement of the thesis-title question ("who bears the cost?"). The "working well" framing invites positive assessment as a confirmation-bias guardrail; the "needs to be figured out" framing surfaces unresolved tensions without accusation. The externality-costliness question migrates into the optional probe P1, which approaches it obliquely through the trajectory of affected people over time rather than through direct cost attribution.

Counter-hypothesis probe: "Is there something firms are doing right - that gets underappreciated - that you'd want to protect?"

Optional probes (selected at interview customisation):

• P1 (externality via trajectory): "When people's roles are affected and they leave an organisation, what do you think happens to them over time - not just immediately, but in the longer run?"

• P2 (time-to-adapt): "Do you think the current pace of change gives organisations enough time to get this right?"

• P3 (reflective close): "If you could change one thing about how the industry handles this, what would it be?"

• P4 (pipeline sustainability - union variant only): "When entry-level work is increasingly done by AI, how do you think about where the next generation of mid- / senior-level staff comes from?"

Variant - Union representative: the stem and the first three optional probes are identical. The pipeline-sustainability probe (P4) was added to the union variant in May 2026 because entry-level erosion is a long-standing union concern that the broader stem does not always surface.

D4. What haven't we asked

"What haven't we asked that you think matters for understanding how this works?"

A pure inductive opener. The question lets themes the protocol missed surface from the participant's own concerns, which is important for the inductive–deductive hybrid orientation of reflexive TA. It guards against the protocol over-determining what is heard. From the union vantage the stem is especially valuable, because reps may carry concerns that do not map onto the four clusters cleanly (cross-firm comparisons, sectoral bargaining patterns, member-affect data).

Variant - Union representative: identical wording.

Surrounding protocol

Pre-interview checklist

Before each interview, the interviewers confirmed:

• Consent form sent in advance, with an invitation at the opening to raise any concerns rather than a full re-read.

• Recording device tested, with a backup.

• The firm-specific Stage-2 guide ready, with placeholder fills and any "questions not to ask for this firm" notes prepared.

• Lead and note-taker roles agreed between the two interviewers.

• Reflexive-journal template open and ready for the post-interview entry.

• A quiet location and reasonable connectivity if the interview was remote.

For union-rep interviews, two further items were checked: the participant's specific representation role (works council member, kollektivavtal local, shop steward, branch officer) and the anonymity stress-test for small unions, where the participant might remain identifiable to insiders even with firm pseudonymisation.

Opening - generic summary

The interview opened with a brief reinforcement of the consent-form provisions the participant had reviewed in advance: voluntary participation, the right to decline any question or pause the recording, anonymisation of the transcript prior to analytical use, firm-identifier and role-descriptor stripping in any quoted material, and analytical-use-only confidentiality. Participants were also informed that they would receive the anonymised transcript after the interview and would retain full discretion to review, redact, or withdraw any segment before the analytical work began. The union-representative variant carried a brief additional acknowledgement of bargaining-confidentiality concerns specific to that role.

Member-check closing

"We'll transcribe this and work on the analysis over the coming months. If you'd like, once we've drafted the themes we're constructing across the interviews, we can share those with you - not the raw transcript, the thematic findings - so you can tell us whether we've interpreted faithfully. Would that be something you'd want?"

Timing

Each interview ran approximately 60 minutes, with the proportions across opening, question clusters, and closing adjusted to participant pace and the cost-bearing probes of Cluster C carrying the heaviest allocation.

Reflexive journal

Each interviewer completed a short reflexive entry within ten minutes of the end of the interview. The two journals were filed independently and compared later. The template asked:

1. Which theoretical frame was most active in your head - legitimacy, espoused-vs-theory-in-use, ethicswashing, externality? Name it.

2. Moments of surprise. Where did the participant say something you didn't expect? What contradicted a pre-interview assumption?

3. Moments of expectation-confirmation. Where did the participant say something that matched your theoretical expectations? Confirmation is a flag for extra scrutiny in coding, not a reason to weight an extract more heavily.

4. Body language and atmosphere notes. Tensions, relaxations, shifts in register, things the recording will not capture.

5. Where did I lead? Any question where you felt you pushed toward a particular answer, or probed harder because the answer matched or did not match expectations.

6. Counter-probe audit. For each counter-hypothesis probe I asked, did I give it equal airtime to the main stem? Any I rushed, skipped, or asked with a different tone? If I skipped one, why?

7. Assumptions I now want to test or revise. What did this interview challenge?

8. Changes for the next interview.

9. One quote that stays with me (paraphrase is fine; for me, not the thesis).

For union-rep interviews, five further prompts applied: an adversarial-presumption check; a confidentiality-respect check; a co-operative-relationship airtime audit; a "speak for whom" accuracy check (union ≠ all workers); and, where the interview was paired with an HR interview at the same firm, a vantage cross-reference note flagging convergences and divergences for later theme development.

Appendix B. Firm corpus brief

Each in-scope firm is summarised here against the dimensions relevant to the thesis: ownership and structural anchor, AI-deployment surface, governance-discourse register, and workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window. Structural qualifiers across the twelve firms are tabulated in Table 3.3 of §3.3.1; per-firm coding-volume figures are in section §3.3 (Table 3.4). Briefs are ordered alphabetically.

Accenture

Accenture is incorporated in Ireland and listed on the NYSE. With roughly 779,000 employees in FY2025 and reported revenue of $69.7 billion, it operates as a global professional-services firm whose role in the corpus is doubled: it is itself a workforce-restructuring case and it is the AI-transformation partner that several other corpus firms (BAT, SAP) contract to deliver their own AI rollouts.

AI is embedded across the firm as a product (the Responsible AI Blueprint, four-pillar framework, eight-principle internal program), as an internal capability (77,000 AI and data practitioners targeted to reach 80,000 in FY26; 550,000 staff reskilled on generative AI fundamentals), and as a client offering (generative AI new bookings of $5.9 billion in FY2025). In late 2025 Accenture announced four major LLM and data partnerships in 16 days (OpenAI, Snowflake, Anthropic, Palantir), each tied to thousands of newly upskilled professionals.

The governance-discourse register is broad. The corpus samples the Responsible AI Blueprint, the Code of Business Ethics (a SOX/NYSE-compelled artefact amended in October 2025), the FY2025 360° Value (sustainability) Report, and the firm's NIST AI RMF and ISO 42001 alignment claims. The Blueprint defines responsible AI as practice that "empowers employees and businesses and fairly impacts customers and society", a four-stakeholder scope that does not include displacement as a governed outcome.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window is unusually direct. In September 2025 Accenture announced an $865 million six-month Business Optimization Program with $344 million in employee severance, framed as a three-pronged talent strategy of upskill, exit, and AI-driven operating efficiencies. CEO Julie Sweet, on the Q4 FY25 earnings call and on CNBC, named the threshold publicly: "exiting on a compression timeline people for whom reskilling isn't a viable path". The same 10-K narrates the event in four registers (Item 1 Human Capital, Item 1A Risk Factors, Item 7 MD&A, Item 8 Note 1), the most genre-stratified single-document presentation in the sample.

British American Tobacco

British American Tobacco is a UK-headquartered, LSE-listed tobacco and nicotine firm that also files an SEC Form 20-F. At end of 2024 it reported 48,989 full-time-equivalent staff across more than 100 markets and is independently certified on living-wage and on within-1% gender and ethnicity pay equity. BAT sells Velo and other smokeless products in Scandinavia but has no Sweden-specific workforce disclosures in the corpus window.

AI deployment is framed as operational rather than strategic-substitution. The firm uses AI in supply-chain optimisation and agricultural data analysis, runs a generative AI lab in Dubai (its first consumer-packaged-goods AI lab), and accesses "agentic AI" capabilities through its July 2025 outsourcing partnership with Accenture. AI governance failure is listed as a principal risk in the FY2024 Annual and Sustainability Report, with EU AI Act fines explicitly quantified.

The governance-discourse register is consolidated in the Annual and Sustainability Report and in earnings transcripts rather than in any standalone AI ethics code. BAT defines "AI Systems" under a Responsible and Ethical AI Framework whose definition closely mirrors EU AI Act Article 3. Frameworks named include the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights, the German Lieferkettengesetz, Modern Slavery Acts in three jurisdictions, ILO child-labour conventions, and CSRD preparation for 2026 reporting.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window is structurally distinctive: AI-mediated workforce restructuring routed through outsourcing rather than direct layoffs. The Fit2Win programme announced in mid-2025 was expanded by year-end to £600 million in associated restructuring costs against £600 million in annual savings by 2028, with the GBS and Supply Network Operations functions transferred to Accenture. No document in the corpus discloses how many BAT workers are affected, and the FY2025 preliminary results press release of 12 February 2026, published the same day as the FY2025 earnings call, omits Fit2Win entirely.

Electrolux Group

Electrolux Group is a Swedish home-appliance manufacturer, headquartered in Stockholm and listed on Nasdaq Stockholm. It reported approximately 39,200 employees at end of 2025 (down from 45,452 average in 2023) and SEK 140.1 billion in revenue. About 1,500 of its workers are based in Sweden. It has a strong labour-relations architecture (International Framework Agreement with IF Metall, Unionen, and IndustriAll; three union representatives on the Board; Koncernfacklig delegation at Group level), distinctive within the corpus.

AI deployment in the corpus window is framed exclusively as a consumer product and operations feature. The AEG AI TasteAssist oven function is the flagship AI reference; "digitalization including connectivity, software, sensors, and AI-based algorithms" appears in product development discourse. The FY2025 Annual Report escalates to a generative AI productivity statement ("expected to enhance productivity, accelerate processes and increase flexibility across core operations") and introduces AI tools for ergonomic risk assessment, but no AI governance policy or AI ethics report sits in the corpus bundle.

The governance-discourse register is sustainability-oriented rather than AI-specific. Both the FY2024 and FY2025 reports are CSRD/ESRS-aligned and cite UNGP, OECD Guidelines, ILO conventions, ISO 45001, and ISO 50001. EU AI Act, NIST AI RMF, and ISO 42001 are absent from the bundle.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window is consistent across two restructuring waves but pointedly decoupled from AI in first-party disclosures. The October 2023 organisational-simplification press release announced approximately 3,000 affected positions and a SEK 2 to 2.5 billion charge attributed to "weak consumer demand and competitive pressure" and to input-cost discrepancies between regions. The April 2026 Jászberény (Hungary) plant-closure press release announced about 600 affected employees and a SEK 0.6 billion charge attributed to "stagnant market demand, price pressure, and increasing constraints on cost competitiveness". Neither wave names AI as a driver, even though a SEK 8 billion 2018 to 2024 automation programme runs alongside a cumulative headcount decline of about 6,200.

Google (Alphabet)

Google operates as a subsidiary of Alphabet Inc., a US-headquartered, Nasdaq-listed technology firm with substantial Swedish operations. The corpus samples its standalone Google-branded materials rather than the Alphabet 10-K. Google originated the 2018 AI Principles, which anchor the earliest text in the corpus and continue to be revised (the 2024 update is restated in the firm's 2025 Responsible AI Progress Report).

AI is positioned as the company's strategic centre of gravity. The corpus window captures the December 2023 launch of Gemini, the consolidation of Google Brain and DeepMind into a single research unit under Demis Hassabis, the Bard-to-Gemini product transition, and the 2025 Frontier Safety Framework. The 2025 Responsible AI Progress Report claims a "mature" rating against NIST AI RMF and ISO/IEC 42001 for Google Cloud AI and maps to the UK AI Safety Institute's Responsible Capability Scaling architecture.

The governance-discourse register tilts US- and UK-anchored. Sampled documents include the AI Principles, the 2025 Responsible AI Progress Report (citing 300-plus research papers), the Google Code of Conduct (last updated 17 January 2024), the Form 8-K Exhibit 99.1 carrying the FY2023 Q4 earnings statement, and an Alphabet CEO interview on Bloomberg Tech (June 2025). EU AI Act, GDPR, ILO, and UNGP do not appear in the coded extracts.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window is the paradigmatic implicit-juxtaposition case. The 20 January 2023 Pichai memo announced 12,000 role eliminations and paired "early investments in AI" with "roles we're eliminating" in adjacent paragraphs without a stated causal link. The 30 January 2024 Form 8-K records $2.1 billion in employee severance and related charges, with the CEO naming AI and the CFO naming "durably re-engineer our cost base" inside the same document. Bloomberg in June 2025 noted recurring layoff rounds through 2024 to 2025, framed by the CEO as engineering-productivity uplift rather than as substitution.

IBM

IBM is a US-headquartered enterprise software, consulting, and infrastructure firm, NYSE-listed, operating in more than 175 countries. In FY2025 it reported 264,300 employees and $67.5 billion in revenue, with a $12.5 billion generative-AI book of business since inception. IBM has no Sweden-specific workforce disclosure in the corpus.

The firm carries an unusual triple role: AI vendor (the watsonx platform, Granite foundation models, watsonx.governance), AI deployer ("Client Zero" automation across HR, finance, sales operations, and IT, with $4.5 billion in productivity savings since 2023), and AI governance thought leader. The AI Ethics Board, established in 2019, is co-chaired by the Chief Privacy and Trust Officer and the AI Ethics Global Leader, supported by a Policy Advisory Committee, AI Ethics Focal Points in each business unit, and a grassroots Tech Ethics Advocacy Network.

The governance-discourse register sampled by the corpus is the most elaborate in the bundle: three dedicated AI-governance documents (a 2023 governance-framework blog, a 2024 AI Safety and Governance Framework aligned to the AI Seoul Summit, and a 2024 Five-Year retrospective on the AI Ethics Board), plus the Form 10-K FY2024 and the FY2025 Annual Report. IBM co-founded the Partnership on AI in 2016 and the AI Alliance with Meta in 2023, has open-source toolkits (AI Fairness 360, Explainability 360, Adversarial Robustness 360), claims an "Augmenting Human Intelligence" first principle, and publishes EU AI Act compliance guidance.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window is the most explicit-and-yet-undocumented in the sample. On 1 May 2023, CEO Arvind Krishna told Bloomberg that approximately 30% of IBM's roughly 26,000 back-office roles, about 7,800 jobs, could be replaced by AI and automation over five years. An IBM spokesperson confirmed attrition as part of the mechanism. No first-party press release, SEC filing, or AI governance document in the corpus reproduces or quantifies this hiring-pause; FTE actually grew from about 260,000 in 2023 to 264,300 in 2025, masking the back-office composition shift.

IKEA (Ingka)

IKEA's in-corpus entity is Ingka Group, the Dutch-headquartered operational arm of the Ingka Foundation. Ingka runs the great majority of IKEA retail stores worldwide and is privately held under cooperative-foundation ownership rather than as a listed company. The brand is Swedish-rooted (Älmhult) and reports approximately 166,000 co-workers globally. Ingka files CSRD-aligned reports and is an EU AI Pact signatory.

AI deployment in the corpus window is sustained and customer-facing. The Billie chatbot resolved 47% of call-centre enquiries by mid-2023, generating around 13 million euro in savings while the firm reports having reskilled 8,500 call-centre co-workers. Subsequent rollouts include Hej Copilot, the My AI Portal generative-AI environment, and an internal AI inventory with risk classification. AI literacy reached approximately 11,062 co-workers cumulatively by FY25.

The governance-discourse register has a clear seam. The 2019 Code of Business Conduct anchors only to internal Kamprad-era authority and is silent on technology-driven role change. From 2023 onward, the firm anchors heavily to external regulatory canon: EU AI Act, EU Commission Ethics Guidelines for Trustworthy AI (2019), OECD Recommendation on AI (2019), UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI (2021), WEF AI Governance Alliance, Partnership on AI. ILO and union frameworks are notably absent from the AI-governance citations.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window decouples AI from restructuring rhetorically. The FY24 CEO letter explicitly couples AI to "reducing costs", and the same year shows a roughly 3,060 net headcount decline (unattributed). On 19 March 2026 Ingka announced that approximately 800 office roles "may become redundant" in Group Functions, with related Sweden (145) and Norway (50 to 60) cuts implied, framed as "simpler organisation" enabling speed and agility. The same-day Reuters interview with CEO Juvencio Maeztu rationalises the cuts via "complexity" and "agility" and does not name AI. Embedded Young Leaders' Forum letters inside the FY24 and FY25 reports name the AI-workforce gap from within the firm's own publications.

Klarna

Klarna is a Stockholm-headquartered fintech firm operating in the buy-now-pay-later segment. It listed on the NYSE in September 2025 under ticker KLAR via a Form F-1 prospectus, with final IPO valuation of $15.1 billion against the 2021 SoftBank-round peak of $46 billion. At end of 2025 it reported 2,795 full-time-equivalent employees across 26 countries, down from a 2022 peak of 5,527. Of its Swedish workforce, 1,453 employees are union-affiliated per the F-1 disclosure.

AI deployment is publicly positioned at substitution scale. The February 2024 OpenAI-co-branded press release claimed Klarna's AI assistant performed "the equivalent work of 700 full-time agents", handling two-thirds of customer-service chats. By mid-2024 revenue per employee had risen from $344,000 to $821,000. AI is also embedded in HR as the "Amplifier" engagement-survey chatbot.

The governance-discourse register sampled by the corpus exhibits a striking compulsion-vs-election split. The Form F-1 (14 March 2025) carries the explicit AI-to-headcount causal chain in plain prose. The Code of Business Conduct (approved 29 August 2025, after the F-1 and after the CNBC interview) cites the FCA Handbook, ECOA, Dodd-Frank, FCPA, BaFin MaRisk, the SFSA, the UK Modern Slavery Act 2015, and ILO Conventions, but contains zero references to EU AI Act, ISO 42001, NIST AI RMF, or any AI-ethics framework. The CSRD/ESRS Sustainability Statement mentions AI exactly once (GHG-emissions monitoring).

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window contains the corpus's most explicit first-party AI-to-headcount attribution: the F-1 states that the headcount reduction "resulted from our strategic decision to reduce our overall headcount and drive operational efficiency by leveraging AI in our business". On CNBC (14 May 2025), CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski described shrinking from about 5,000 to about 3,000 employees via "investments in artificial intelligence and natural attrition" plus a 2023 hiring freeze, and partially walked back the AI-only customer-service model citing quality issues. The FY25 Annual Report records total severance of SEK 1.5 million.

Länsförsäkringar

Länsförsäkringar is a Swedish mutual-cooperative federation of 23 customer-owned regional insurance companies that jointly own Länsförsäkringar AB. Approximately 3.9 million customer-owners hold ownership; there are no external shareholders. The federation operates exclusively in Sweden, employs approximately 10,200 people at end of 2025 (up from 9,500 in 2024), and operates across insurance, banking, pension, and real-estate brokerage. The cooperative-mutual structure is distinctive within the corpus.

AI deployment is broad and framed as augmentation. The internal LF-GPT assistant moved from approximately 5,000 monthly users in 2024 to 70% of the federation's employees in 2025, one of the highest disclosed internal generative-AI adoption rates in the sample. AI is deployed in claims, fraud detection, customer chatbots, AI code assistants for system developers, Knowledge Graphs and RAG pilots, and a "Smart Assessment" claims-analysis tool. The subsidiary Sejfa functions as an AI test bed before federation-wide rollout. AI governance was formally established in 2025.

The governance-discourse register is sparse and locally anchored. The two Annual Reviews (the lighter, non-statutory genre Länsförsäkringar publishes) carry the AI content. Broader governance references SFDR, PRI, PRB, PCAF carbon accounting, and ESRS sustainability reporting. The AI-specific governance framework is described without naming EU AI Act, GDPR, ISO 42001, NIST AI RMF,

OECD AI Principles, UNGP, UNESCO, or WEF; this canon-absent pattern is shared with Klarna and Nordea among the three Nordic financial firms in the corpus.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window is the inverse of the substitution pattern: no layoff events, and headcount grew by 700 during the period of active AI deployment. CEO Fredrik Bergström Collén (2024) and his successor Mathias Dalemo (2025) both name adaptation as the central challenge ("the biggest challenge is not the technology itself but our ability to adapt") without disclosing structured reskilling, formal adaptation programmes, AI-readiness assessments, or worker consultation on AI deployment. Neither Annual Review mentions collective bargaining or unions, despite Sweden's industrial-relations norms.

Microsoft

Microsoft is a US-headquartered, Nasdaq-listed software, cloud, and AI firm with substantial Swedish operations. In FY2025 (ended 30 June 2025) it reported 228,000 full-time employees, $281.7 billion in revenue, and the widest operating margin since 2002. Its 9-document corpus bundle is the largest in the sample.

AI deployment is positioned as a generational platform shift, with the firm describing itself as moving from a "software factory" to an "intelligence engine". The corpus captures the foundational OpenAI partnership extension of January 2023, the November 2023 launch of Microsoft 365 Copilot, the 100-million-plus monthly Copilot users by FY2025, and Azure AI Foundry, which carries more than 11,000 models. Microsoft has obtained an ISO/IEC 42001:2023 certification for M365 Copilot.

The governance-discourse register is dense. The corpus samples the standing Trust Code (Standards of Business Conduct), the inaugural 2024 Responsible AI Transparency Report, the 2025 Responsible AI Transparency Report (EU AI Act and ISO 42001 focused), and the FY2023 and FY2025 Annual Reports. Microsoft operates a six-principle AI ethics framework, a Responsible AI Council, the Office of Responsible AI, a Sensitive Uses programme (since 2017), an AI Red Team (since 2018), and a Frontier Governance Framework.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window spans three layoff cycles totalling approximately 25,000 workers over 30 months. The January 2023 wave (about 10,000 cuts) was disclosed via a Form 8-K filed under Item 7.01 (Regulation FD) with the CEO memo attached as Exhibit 99.1, and the memo disclosed an itemised severance, healthcare, stock-vesting, notice, and transition-services package. The FY2025 waves (about 6,000 in May 2025 plus 9,000 in July 2025) had no equivalent Form 8-K and the July CEO memo discloses none of the 2023 transition dimensions. The FY2025 Annual Report does not narrate either FY25 wave; general and administrative expenses, which include severance, fell 5% year-on-year despite the cuts.

Nordea

Nordea is a Nordic banking multinational headquartered in Helsinki, listed on the Nasdaq Helsinki, Stockholm, and Copenhagen exchanges. It reported 28,747 full-time-equivalent staff at end of Q1 2026, down approximately 5% year-on-year from 30,343. Sweden is one of the four Nordic home markets but is not broken out as a separate workforce reporting unit in the corpus documents. Nordea operates under the EU AI Act high-risk regime for financial-services AI.

AI deployment is framed as central to the Nordea 2030 strategy. The corpus records customer-facing AI products (AI News Summary, Global AI Innovators Fund) and Group-functions AI uptake, and the firm couples AI explicitly to "Nordic scale" and "process optimisation" as the engine of a 600 million euro annual gross cost take-out by 2030.

The governance-discourse register sampled by the corpus is narrow. The 16 July 2025 Code of Conduct anchors itself in five international instruments (UN Global Compact, UDHR, ILO Conventions, UN Convention against Corruption, Rio Declaration) and codifies labour-rights via ILO-anchored clauses including living wage, freedom of association, adherence to collective bargaining, and child- and forced-labour abolition. The Code references no AI-governance instruments: no EU AI Act, OECD AI Principles, UNESCO AI Ethics, GDPR, ISO 42001, or NIST AI RMF.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window is the corpus's clearest specimen of within-firm, cross-genre AI-attribution stripping. The 17 March 2026 stock-exchange release announcing approximately 1,500 affected positions and 190 million euro in Q1 2026 items affecting comparability states explicitly: "with Nordic scale, the impact of AI and process optimisation, Nordea expects to have fewer employees in the future than today". The Q1 2026 Financial Report, filed 5 weeks later (21 April 2026), reproduces the restructuring paragraphs nearly verbatim but removes the AI-attribution sentence and substitutes "active cost management" as the agentless cause.

SAP

SAP is a German enterprise-software firm dual-listed on Frankfurt and the NYSE, headquartered in Walldorf and operating as a Societas Europaea. At end of 2024 it reported approximately 109,000 employees. It is the only Continental-European, works-council-governed case in the corpus: a multinational SE Works Council covers Sweden among more than 25 EEA states, 36% of employees are covered by collective bargaining agreements, and the firm operates under 262 EEA labour agreements.

AI deployment is centred on the Joule generative-AI copilot, launched September 2023 and embedded across HR, finance, supply chain, procurement, and customer-experience cloud applications. The firm operates a longstanding partnership with Accenture, expanded in May 2025 as the "Connected Intelligence" agentic-AI delivery alliance. SAP is in scope as both EU AI Act deployer and provider.

The governance-discourse register sampled by the corpus is wide. The bundle includes the SAP Global Code of Ethics and Business Conduct (2022 baseline; v2.1 update March 2025), the Global AI Ethics Policy and AI Ethics Handbook (August to September 2024, UNESCO-anchored), the Form 20-F FY2024, the first CSRD/ESRS-compliant Integrated Report (FY2024), two same-day January 2024 press releases (Ambition 2025 and the Q4/FY2023 results), and a CEO Bloomberg interview. The AI Ethics Policy anchors explicitly to the UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window is announced first-party but then revised under SEC compulsion. The 23 January 2024 Ambition 2025 press release announced approximately 8,000 affected positions and a 2 billion euro preliminary restructuring charge, framing AI as enabler rather than as causal driver. CEO Christian Klein on Bloomberg the next day paired the announcement with a 1 billion euro AI investment counterweight. By the Form 20-F FY2024 (February 2025) the realised figures were approximately 10,000 affected positions and 3.144 billion euro in restructuring expenses, a 25% upward revision surfaced only in the SEC-compelled register, without a public revision narrative bridging the two.

Salesforce

Salesforce is a US-headquartered cloud-services and CRM firm, NYSE-listed, with Swedish operations. At end of FY26 (31 January 2026) it reported 83,334 employees. Its US workforce is non-unionised; foreign subsidiaries operate with works-councils or unions per local norms. The firm positions itself publicly as the "#1 AI CRM".

AI deployment in the corpus window centres on Einstein GPT (launched March 2023, the firm's first generative-AI-for-CRM product) and Agentforce (the autonomous-agents platform launched at Dreamforce 2024 with Atlas reasoning engine), plus Data 360 and a $250 million Generative AI Fund operated by Salesforce Ventures. The FY26 10-K MD&A explicitly attributes part of the firm's expense-ratio reduction to "increasing our sales productivity, which includes the use of AI and agents".

The governance-discourse register sampled by the corpus includes the inaugural Trusted AI and Agents Impact Report (February 2025) from the Office of Ethical and Humane Use, the FY24 Stakeholder Impact Report, the Code of Conduct (effective March 2025), the January 2023 Form 8-K filed under SEC Item 2.05 (Material Impairment), the FY26 10-K, and Bloomberg and Logan Bartlett podcast interviews. Salesforce operates a five-principle Trusted AI framework (Accuracy, Safety, Honesty, Empowerment, Sustainability) supported by five governance bodies.

The workforce / cost-allocation signal in the corpus window covers three layoff waves and a register migration over 32 months. The January 2023 Form 8-K disclosed approximately 7,300 role eliminations

(about 10% of the then-73,000 workforce) with $1.0 to 1.4 billion in employee transition, severance, benefits, and share-based compensation, and contained zero AI references. A February 2025 Bloomberg wire reported 1,000 role cuts juxtaposed with AI-agent salesperson hiring. The September 2025 Logan Bartlett podcast carries the clearest first-party CEO attribution in the bundle: Marc Benioff stated he had "reduced it from 9,000 heads to about 5,000" in customer-support roles "because of the benefits and efficiencies of Agentforce". The FY26 10-K records $586 million in FY26 restructuring charges.